Municipal Policy Knowledge and the Limits of Local Democratic Accountability*

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Abstract

Theories of democratic accountability expect voters to observe government performance to reward or punish incumbents accordingly. This paper asks whether residents can accurately identify the policies enacted by their city governments, whether partisan heuristics help or hurt that accuracy, and if that knowledge is sufficient for individuals to hold their city governments accountable for policy. Linking an original survey of over 1,000 American city residents to a comprehensive accounting of the policy decisions of 321 city governments on 20 issues, I show that residents are only marginally better at accurately identifying their city governments' policy than chance, with errors skewing toward over-assuming government action. Use of partisan heuristics does not make residents appear more knowledgeable because most residents cannot correctly identify which policies are more likely to be enacted in Democratic- and Republican-leaning cities. Residents reward and punish their city officials based on their perceptions of congruence between city policy and their preferences, even when those perceptions do not match reality. These findings suggest that individual voters fall short of the expectations given to them by normative theories of local democracy and that frequent misperceptions of city government action hold real consequences for local democratic accountability.

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> *"A popular Government, without popular information, or the means of acquiring it, is but a Prologue to a Farce or a Tragedy; or, perhaps both. Knowledge will forever govern ignorance: And a people who mean to be their own Governors, must arm themselves with the power which knowledge gives."*
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> - James Madison, *Letter to W.T. Barry, 1822*

Representative democracy, as its architects envisioned it, rests on an informed citizenry. To hold government accountable, voters must be able to observe an incumbent's record, weigh those actions against their own preferences, and issue a political reward or punishment accordingly. An ignorant electorate cannot meaningfully evaluate and monitor those who govern them, and thus would be unable to reward responsive officials or sanction those who act against constituent preferences.

Yet, decades of public opinion research demonstrate that this load-bearing requirement for accountability is far from satisfied. The finding that the U.S. public is overwhelmingly uninformed on core aspects of civics and politics remains one of the most robust consensus points in modern social science (Delli Carpini and Keeter 1996; Friedman 1998). If "good decision making requires good information" (Converse 1990, p. 369), the reality of voter ignorance suggests the electorate is ill-equipped to hold government accountable.

Scholars disagree about whether the informational environments of local governments are a favorable or unfavorable terrain for democratic accountability. One tradition holds that government at a smaller scale brings officials and voters closer in proximity, making monitoring and sanctioning more feasible (Dahl and Tufte 1973). Recent empirical work extends this claim, finding that the policies of city governments respond to constituent preferences in the aggregate (Tausanovitch and Warshaw 2014; Einstein and Kogan 2016). A second tradition characterizes local politics as a low-information and low-engagement environment (McDermott 1997 1998; Crowder-Meyer, Gadarian and Trounstine 2020), in which structural features such as nonpartisan ballots and off-cycle elections compounded by the shuttering of local newspapers (Hayes and Lawless 2021) and shifting of remaining

news coverage away from local issues (Martin and McCrain 2019) leave voters with little information on which to base their local electoral decisions. The disagreement between these traditions turns on an empirical question that has received little direct attention: whether residents actually know the policy outputs of their city governments.

Of course, an optimistic school of thought suggests that a lack of direct policy knowledge is not fatal to the democratic enterprise. A substantial body of research establishes that voters need not possess encyclopedic levels of information to hold government accountable and can rely on judgmental shortcuts instead (Brady and Sniderman 1985; Page and Shapiro 1992; Popkin 1994). Chief among these shortcuts is partisanship (Rahn 1993), which has grown more informative as the parties have sorted into increasingly distinct and legible ideological coalitions (Sides, Tausanovitch and Vavreck 2023). As media attention prioritizes national political conflict over local-specific information, voters appear to increasingly rely on national party cues to guide their assessments of local political actors (Hopkins 2018). The importing of partisan cues could prove problematic, however, if the policy decisions of city governments do not neatly mirror the divides of the national parties (Anzia 2021). A resident who assumes that a Democratic-leaning city will inevitably adopt certain policies that a Republican-leaning city will not may be incorrect in their assumptions of what their own city government has actually done. Rather than correcting for voter ignorance, partisan heuristics applied to local government may fail to improve or actively distort residents' perceptions of local policy by substituting an inaccurate picture of city governance for genuine local knowledge.

Resolving these competing possibilities requires directly comparing what policies citizens believe their cities have enacted with their cities' actual policy outputs. This paper asks whether residents' beliefs about which policies have been passed by their city governments align with reality, whether partisan thinking helps or hurts that alignment, and what the consequences of voters' knowledge about municipal policy are for local democratic accountability. To answer these questions, I compile comprehensive data on the

policy actions of hundreds of city governments regarding local policy issues that have been extensively studied in the local political economy literature. I link this information to an original survey of Americans that live within these cities which assesses their knowledge of their city governments' policy choices.

The results indicate that the accuracy of residents' beliefs about their cities' policies is only marginally better than chance would predict, and errors are not random. Misperception most often takes the form of believing the city government has enacted a policy that it has not. The application of partisan heuristic to municipal policy does not make voters appear more knowledgeable about their city because most residents' beliefs about which policies are more likely to be enacted in Democratic- versus Republican-leaning cities are poorly calibrated.

More troubling than the lack of knowledge itself is that these frequently incorrect beliefs about city policy influence how voters evaluate their city governments. Residents' evaluations of their city governments and local incumbents are shaped by the policies they *think* their city has enacted, rather than by those that have been enacted in reality. This alignment between residents' preferences and what they believe their city has done affects evaluations of government and incumbents independently of retrospective assessments of city conditions and shared partisanship with officials. Critically, the factual accuracy of perceptions of city policy is irrelevant to this process. Residents weigh correct and incorrect perceptions of policy congruence roughly equally when forming evaluations, rewarding and punishing their governments and incumbents for what they imagine them to have done rather than their actual policy record.

These findings carry implications for our understanding of local democratic accountability in a highly polarized and nationalized era. While prominent critiques of electoral accountability argue that democracy falls short of its potential because voters blindly punish or reward incumbents for random events outside of their control (Achen and Bartels 2017), this paper introduces an alternative pathway whereby voter cognition may limit

accountability. Rather than responding to irrelevant information, voters appear to respond to perceptions of government action that do not always reflect actual policy outputs. While earlier scholarship found that municipal policies broadly align with resident ideology in the aggregate (Tausanovitch and Warshaw 2014; Einstein and Kogan 2016), the present findings suggest that this aggregate responsiveness is not driven by voters accurately observing and rewarding incumbents for their city governments' policy decisions.

Accountability, Ignorance, and the Promise of Heuristics

The dominant theoretical framework for understanding how elections discipline politicians to ensure responsiveness is a principal-agent model of electoral accountability. Under this framework, voters (the principals) select, monitor, evaluate, and sanction elected representatives (the agents) to ensure policy responsiveness (Fearon 1999), rewarding good behavior or "throwing the rascals out" (Manin, Przeworski and Stokes 1999, p. 42) as a punishment for adverse outcomes (Ferejohn 1986). As such, holding agents accountable is dependent on voters' capacity to observe government actions, attribute them to incumbents, and evaluate whether those actions match their preferences. Yet the theoretical requirement of an informed electorate frequently collides with a stark reality: voter knowledge about government, policymaking, and politics is notoriously sparse (Delli Carpini and Keeter 1996; Friedman 1998).

Nevertheless, a prominent strain of behavioral scholarship maintains that accountability remains possible because voters can rely on judgmental shortcuts, or heuristics, to make decisions approximately aligned with their interests even without high levels of knowledge (Brady and Sniderman 1985; Page and Shapiro 1992; Graber 1994). For instance, voters can rely on the increasingly legible brands of the two major political parties (Sides, Tausanovitch and Vavreck 2023) to make reasonable guesses about partisan can-

didates' would-be behavior in office. Yet, the effectiveness of these shortcuts depends on whether they assist voters in arriving at the same conclusions they would reach if they were fully informed. Evidence suggests that heuristics can also easily deceive voters, leading them to form conclusions contrary to the truth or their objective interests (Kuklinski and Hurley 1994; Lau and Redlawsk 2001; Dancey and Sheagley 2013).

A heuristic's validity heavily depends on the context in which it is used. Partisanship is a useful shortcut to judge between candidates for U.S. Congress, for instance, because Congressional roll-call votes follow party lines more often than not (Dancey and Sheagley 2013; Murphy and Tausanovitch 2026). However, when the informative signal carried by a partisan label is weak or poorly calibrated to the conditions in which it is used, voters relying on it will arrive at distorted conclusions (Boudreau, Elmendorf and MacKenzie 2015). City politics, where elections are frequently nonpartisan and policy debates can be highly technocratic, represents a context where this miscalibration is particularly likely to occur.

The Local Political Information Environment

Some might posture that, in theory, local government should be a highly favorable terrain for democratic accountability. Because municipal governments determine policy over immediate, consequential issues—e.g., public safety, land use, transportation infrastructure, and housing—many of their policy decisions are immediately visible to city residents as they live, move around in, and interact with their communities. Foundational theories of local democracy suggest that the smaller scale of city governance brings officials and residents closer together, facilitating easier observation of government action and incentivizing individuals to participate in and learn about local politics (Dahl and Tufte 1973; Buchanan 1995; Oliver 2012).

Despite these theoretical conditions that predict informed and attentive local elec-

torates, prominent accounts characterize local politics as a low-information, low-engagement political environment (McDermott 1997 1998; Crowder-Meyer, Gadarian and Trounstine 2020). Several features of local politics conspire to produce this setting. Progressive Era reforms introduced nonpartisan ballots and off-cycle election timing to insulate local politics from partisan competition and political machines, stripping the ballot of the cues that voters rely on most heavily in national contests (Schaffner, Streb and Wright 2001; Hajnal and Lewis 2003). On top of these institutional barriers, recent media trends have driven local newspapers out of business and shifted remaining news coverage away from municipal affairs (Martin and McCrain 2019; Hayes and Lawless 2021), dismantling the civic infrastructure traditionally thought to transmit local political information. While some encouraging evidence suggests that voters can rationally respond to information about incumbent performance in local elections when it is made sufficiently visible (Berry and Howell 2007; Burnett and Kogan 2017), these findings say little about what happens in the broader local political environment where such clarity is absent.

Compounding this information scarcity is the rapid nationalization of American politics, or the broad shift whereby voters increasingly evaluate local political actors through the lens of national partisan conflict (Hopkins 2018). Voters applying partisan frames to local politics will likely assume that cities inhabited by more voters that support Democrats in national elections will adopt different policies than those inhabited by more Republican voters. However, municipal policymaking is frequently orthogonal to national ideological and partisan divides (Anzia 2021), or as former New York City Mayor Fiorello LaGuardia put it, "there is no Republican or Democratic way to pick up the garbage."[1] As a consequence, a partisan heuristic may often be poorly calibrated to municipal policy. A resident using their city's partisan character to approximate its policy output, absent genuine policy knowledge, may be led to incorrect conclusions because their beliefs about

[1]Quoted by Diana Lind, *StreetsBlogUSA*, 2024. This quote is mostly apocryphal, and some disagree over whether LaGuardia said "there is no Republican or Democratic way to pick up the garbage" or "there is no Republican or Democratic way to clean the streets." Whichever he actually said, the point remains the same.

which municipal policies to associate with which types of cities are shaped more by national expectations or partisan stereotypes than the realities of local governance. Whether these distortions materialize and what consequences they carry for accountability depends on how closely residents' beliefs about city policy track reality.

Policy Congruence as the Micro-foundation of Political Accountability

A substantial body of research attempting to quantify the quality of democratic representation asks whether the policy decisions of elected officials and governments align, or are congruent, with the preferences of those they represent. This tradition dates to Miller and Stokes (1963), who found that the correlation between constituent opinion and legislator behavior varied considerably across issue domains and fell short of their idealized standard of representative democracy. Subsequent scholarship has extended this inquiry to subnational governments with increasingly precise measurement, finding modest to encouraging evidence that state and local government policy responds to constituent preferences (Lax and Phillips 2012; Tausanovitch and Warshaw 2014; Einstein and Kogan 2016; Caughey and Warshaw 2022).

Implicit in this line of research is an assumption about how accountability functions at the individual level. Each individual facilitates accountability by rewarding incumbents when policy is congruent with their preferences and punishing when it is not. The aggregation of individual voters behaving in this manner ensures that the majority's preference for a given policy is satisfied. Ansolabehere and Kuriwaki (2022) provide perhaps the most direct evidence for this individual-level mechanism in congressional representation, showing that voters reward their members of Congress specifically for issue-level congruence with their own preferences (although see Murphy and Tausanovitch 2026). For this individual-driven aggregate accountability to occur, the accountability mechanism runs

from government or official action being congruent with an individual's preferences, to the individual's observation of that congruence, to electoral reward or punishment.

Yet we should be careful in assuming voters will recognize actual policy congruence simply because researchers can measure it. This assumption may be defensible in the context of congressional representation, where partisan signals are strong and information is more readily available, but it is harder to sustain in the local context as described above. If a scarcity of reliable information nudges residents' beliefs about municipal policy to diverge from reality, residents may reward governments for preferred policies that were never enacted, punish for the presumed lack of desired policies they have in fact adopted, or otherwise evaluate government performance on the basis of a false picture of local policy. The remainder of this paper provides evidence that this is often the case.

Data

To assess residents' knowledge of their city governments' policy choices and its consequences for political accountability, the analyses combine data from two sources. The first is a comprehensive accounting of currently enacted municipal policies within U.S. cities with populations about 75,000 residents relating to twenty key policy areas. The second is a demographically representative survey of 1,028 American adults sampled from residents living within those cities. The proceeding sections describe the data gathering procedures for each source.

City Policy Data

This study draws on information about the policy decisions of the 484 U.S. municipalities home to a population of more than 75,000 residents as of the 2020 U.S. Census.[2] These span twenty salient policy areas. Several criteria guided policy selection. First, each pol-

[2]Supplementary Information Section A.1 (Figure A.1) presents a map of these 484 municipalities.

icy falls within the jurisdiction of city governments. Second, together, the twenty policy areas span major functional domains of local governance that have been widely studied in the local political economy literature, including land use and zoning (Trounstine 2018; Einstein 2020), housing and homelessness (Hankinson 2018; Einstein and Willison 2025), public safety (Owens and Ba 2021; De Benedictis-Kessner et al. 2025), environmental sustainability (Feiock et al. 2014), transportation (Taylor and Morris 2015), and resident inclusivity (Cravens 2015; Taylor, Lewis and Haider-Markel 2020). Third, each policy is one that residents could plausibly encounter as a topic of local debate or campaign discussion, rather than an obscure administrative matter unlikely to reach the public's attention.

While no battery of twenty policies can be exhaustive, restricting attention to salient policies spanning widely studied domains of municipal governance provides a reasonable basis for assessing local policy knowledge, and one that plausibly stacks the deck in favor of finding accountability. If residents cannot accurately identify policies of this kind, it is unlikely they would perceive more obscure or technical ones any better. Table 1 presents the twenty policies on which data were gathered and how they were defined for the purpose of this study.[3]

To facilitate a systematic data collection process on policymaking in these twenty areas across hundreds of cities, data gathering began through the implementation of an automated internet search procedure using GPT-5's web-search capability accessed through the OpenAI API. The web-search tool allowed the agent to search for up-to-date information via the internet and provide responses accompanied by detailed citation information based on a set of explicit instructions. See Section A.2 of the Supplementary Information for a more detailed discussion of the implementation of this automated search process.

[3]To address potential concerns that the paper's findings are a product of the particular policies included in this battery, Section A.5 of the Supplementary Information reports sensitivity analyses in which each policy is excluded from the data, as well as simulations that randomly drop five or ten of the twenty policies from the analyses. Across each of these specifications, the estimated relationships remain consistent in magnitude, direction, and statistical significance with those reported in the main text, indicating that the results are not an artifact of the particular policies surveyed.

Table 1: City Policies Under Investigation

Policy	Definition	Policy	Definition
Environmental Sustainability		***Land Use/Zoning***	
Climate Emergency Declaration	Officially declared climate change is a public emergency	Accessory Dwelling Unit	Allows homes to contain a secondary dwelling unit, such as a garage/basement apartment or backyard cottage, to be built on the same property as a primary residence
E.V. Charger Incentives	Requires or incentivizes property owners and developers to install electric vehicle charging stations	Big Box Retailer Restrictions	Forbids or severely limits the establishment of big-box and warehouse-style retail stores (e.g., Costco, Sam's Club) within the city
Zero Emission Fleet Plan	Committed to transition all government-owned vehicles to zero emission or electric vehicles	Inclusionary Zoning	Requires or incentivizes developers to set aside some units in new housing developments as affordable for low- or moderate-income residents
Housing/Homelessness		***Policing/Public Safety***	
Anti-Displacement Assistance	Requires landlords to pay relocation costs to tenants displaced through no-fault evictions, such as when a property is demolished or converted	Civilian Police Oversight Committee	Authorizes a committee of civilian volunteers to conduct investigations on the conduct of the police department
Homeless Response Unit	Created a new government office to oversee and coordinate the city's response to homelessness	Mental Health Co-Responder	Sends a mental health professional alongside a police officer to respond to calls involving mental health and substance use crises
Housing First	Prioritizes placing homeless individuals into permanent housing quickly, without requiring sobriety or mental health treatment as a precondition	Police Demilitarization	Limits the types of military-style weapons and equipment, such as armored vehicles or tear gas, that the police department can obtain or use
Just Cause Evicition	Prohibits landlords from evicting tenants without a specific legal reason, such as nonpayment of rent or property damage		
Inclusivity		***Transit Infrastructure***	
D.E.I. Initiative	Advances diversity, equity, and inclusion in the city government through a D.E.I program or office	"15-Minute City" Plan	Enacted into law a plan to make neighborhoods walkable enough that residents can reach daily necessities like groceries, parks, and schools within a 15-minute walk or bike ride from home
Gender Neutral Language	Requires all language in city documents to be gender neutral (e.g., "firefighter" instead of "fireman")	E-scooter/Bike Share	Allows private companies to operate shared e-scooter and bike rental services on city streets
LGBT Non-Discrimination	Prohibits the discrimination of individuals based on sexual orientation and gender identity in housing and employment	Removal of Off Street Parking Minimums	Does not require developers to include a minimum number of off-street parking spaces in new residential and/or commercial buildings
		Transit-Signal Priority/Bus Lanes	Establishes bus-only dedicated lanes and traffic signals on major city streets

A team of trained human researchers audited model-generated data entries to assess the model output's accuracy and made corrections where necessary. For this study, each policy in each city is coded as a yes-no binary which indicates whether the policy is present or absent in a given city as of the time the study was conducted. Table 2 communicates the prevalence of each of the twenty policies in the cities from which respondents were sampled.

The complete dataset includes information on relevant policymaking actions (city ordinances, resolutions, charter amendments, executive orders, official policy publications) pertaining to the twenty policy areas in each of the 484 U.S. municipalities with populations greater than 75,000 residents as of the 2020 U.S. Census. This sample spans medium- to large-sized cities and captures substantial variation in urban forms and geographic contexts. These municipalities govern more than one-third of the U.S. population and more than a majority of Americans that live within municipal boundaries. Cities above this population threshold are most likely to possess the administrative capacity and institutional autonomy necessary for meaningful discretion over the set of policies the present study investigates (Oliver 2012). Furthermore, previous data collection efforts have noted the difficulty in finding reliable information on governance in smaller cities through the internet (Hopkins and Pettingill 2015; De Benedictis-Kessner and Warshaw 2016).

Original Survey on City Residents

These policy data are linked to the responses of an original survey of U.S. adults demographically representative of the national population (N = 1,028) sampled from those living within the 484 U.S. municipalities with populations over 75,000 residents. The survey was fielded from April 23–28, 2026. Respondents were recruited by Verasight via random address-based sampling, random person-to-person text messaging, and dynamic online

Table 2: Prevalence of Policy Enactment in Respondents' Cities

Policy	Respondents Living in Cities Where Policy is Present
Accessory Dwelling Unit	877 (85.3%)
Mental Health Co-Responder	762 (74.1%)
Homeless Response Unit	691 (67.2%)
Removal of Off Street Parking Minimums	647 (62.9%)
LGBT Non-discrimination	638 (62.1%)
Civilian Police Oversight Committee	625 (60.8%)
D.E.I. Initiative	618 (60.1%)
Housing First	550 (53.5%)
Transit-Signal Priority/Bus Lanes	494 (48.1%)
E-scooter/Bike Share	450 (43.8%)
"15-Minute City" Plan	442 (43%)
Inclusionary Zoning	417 (40.6%)
Zero Emission Fleet Plan	392 (38.1%)
Climate Emergency Declaration	325 (31.6%)
Just Cause Eviction	255 (24.8%)
E.V. Charger Incentives	233 (22.7%)
Anti-Displacement Assistance	142 (13.8%)
Big Box Retailer Restrictions	100 (9.7%)
Police Demilitarization	83 (8.1%)
Gender Neutral Language	42 (4.1%)
Total:	1,028

targeting. First, respondents indicated the municipality in which they live[4] and provided information on their length of residence, partisanship, interest in public affairs, turnout in the most recent local election, and other demographic information. Soon after, the survey asked how much respondents approved of the way their city government is currently doing its job, whether they would vote to re-elect their current mayor if the election were today, if they think their current mayor is a Democrat or Republican (or more likely to be either, in cases with nonpartisan elections), and if they would say their city is a better or worse place for someone to live in today compared to a few years ago.

The survey then presented respondents with the definitions of the twenty policies (as defined in Table 1) one at at time in three separate blocks of questions. In the first block,

[4]Section A.1 of the Supplementary Information (Figure A.2) presents a map of the cities in which the sample's respondents live.

a question asking respondents to indicate whether they believed each item describes actions taken by their city government accompanied each policy definition. Respondents were not given an option to indicate "I don't know." This is because allowing people who are uncertain but still somewhat knowledgeable to opt out of answering can introduce systematic bias in estimates of knowledge (Mondak and Davis 2001; Luskin and Bullock 2011). Instead, respondents were encouraged to give their best guess if they were unsure. The second block reintroduced respondents to each of the policy definitions one by one and asked whether they would support or oppose each if it were enacted in their city. The final block presented the policies once again and asked respondents to indicate whether they think each would be more likely to be enacted in a city where most voters are Democrats, in a city where most voters are Republicans, or equally likely in both types of cities.

The order in which the policies were presented was randomized for each respondent. Additionally, the presentation of the survey was randomized such that half of the respondents answered the block of questions asking for their perceptions of their city governments' actions first and the block of question inquiring their preferences for each policy second, and another half of respondents answered these in the reverse order. To minimize potential survey fatigue from answering multiple series of similarly formatted questions, filler questions separated each of the three blocks.

Measurement

These data sources supply the key variables used in the analyses, each described in turn.

Knowledge

A respondent's belief concerning a policy's enactment by their city government is accurate when it matches the city's actual policy record. For instance, if a respondent believes

their city has a plan to transition the city fleet to zero emission vehicles, and the city in which they lives has actually enacted such a plan, their belief is accurate for that policy. Each respondent is given an accuracy score or rate that describes the proportion of the twenty policies in which that respondent's beliefs about their city's policies mirror reality, ranging from 0 (always incorrect) to 1 (always correct).

Perceptions of Partisanship

Respondents also reported their beliefs pertaining the partisan composition of their city's residents and of which type of city is more likely to enact each policy. The city partisan composition measure originates from a question asking respondents to estimate the share of votes cast in their city for Kamala Harris in the 2024 presidential election, which is then simplified into a binary that captures whether the respondent believes their city to be majority Democratic or majority Republican. Measures of the actual partisan composition of each city come from aggregating precinct level 2024 presidential election returns within municipal boundaries (precinct election return data is sourced from Datar et al. 2026). Additionally for each policy, respondents indicated whether they believe it is more likely for it be enacted in a city where most voters are Democrats or Republicans, or equally likely in both types of cities.

Policy Congruence, Actual and Perceived

For each policy, a respondent experiences policy congruence when their city government's policy matches their own preference for that policy. The analyses distinguish between two types of policy congruence: actual policy congruence and perceptions of policy congruence. Actual policy congruence occurs when the city government's policy in reality corresponds with a respondent's preference for that policy. Similarly, perceived policy congruence occurs when the respondent's perception of their city's policy correspondents

with the respondent's preference for that policy. If the respondent's belief about a policy in their city is accurate, then their actual congruence and perceived congruence for that policy will be identical. Table 3 provides a non-exhaustive list of examples of how actual and perceived congruence would be defined for a hypothetical respondent i based on their perceptions and preferences on a set of hypothetical policies.

Table 3: Measuring Policy Congruence & Perception Accuracy for a Hypothetical Respondent

Respondent	Policy	Reality	Perception	Preference	Perception Accuracy	Actual Congruence	Perceived Congruence
i	*x*	Present	Present	Support	Accurate	Congruent (+1)	Congruent (+1)
i	*y*	Absent	Absent	Oppose	Accurate	Congruent (+1)	Congruent (+1)
i	*z*	Present	Present	Oppose	Accurate	Incongruent (-1)	Incongruent (-1)
i	*a*	Present	Absent	Support	Inaccurate	Congruent (+1)	Incongruent (-1)
i	*b*	Absent	Present	Support	Inaccurate	Incongruent (-1)	Congruent (+1)
i	*c*	Present	Absent	Oppose	Inaccurate	Incongruent (-1)	Congruent (+1)

Each policy-respondent pairing is coded as +1 if there is congruence, 0 if the respondent neither supports nor opposes the policy, and -1 if there is incongruence. Cumulative actual and perceptions of policy congruence scores are then generated for each respondent by taking the sum of the individual policy scores and dividing them by the total number of policies. As such, these cumulative scores range from -1 to +1. A negative value suggests that a respondent's preferences are more often incongruent with their city's policies (or their beliefs pertaining to those policies), while a positive value suggests they are more often congruent.

Perceptions of policy congruence can be further decomposed into perceptions that are correct and incorrect. These decomposed measures reflect the net number of policies on which a respondent's beliefs match their preferences, among beliefs that are true or false respectively, divided by the total number of policies. Both range from -1 to 1 and sum to the respondent's overall perceptions of policy congruence score.

Accountability Outcome Variables

In assessing the impact of policy knowledge on residents' ability to hold their city governments accountable, the primary relationship of interest is whether respondents reward or sanction their city government in a manner consistent with their preferences. Two outcome measures are informative on whether this is the case. The first is a respondent's approval of the way their city government is doing its job, which is measured on a scale from 1–7. The second is a respondent's electoral support for a local incumbent, measured as a dichotomous variable that captures their willingness to re-elect their incumbent mayor were the election held today.

Results

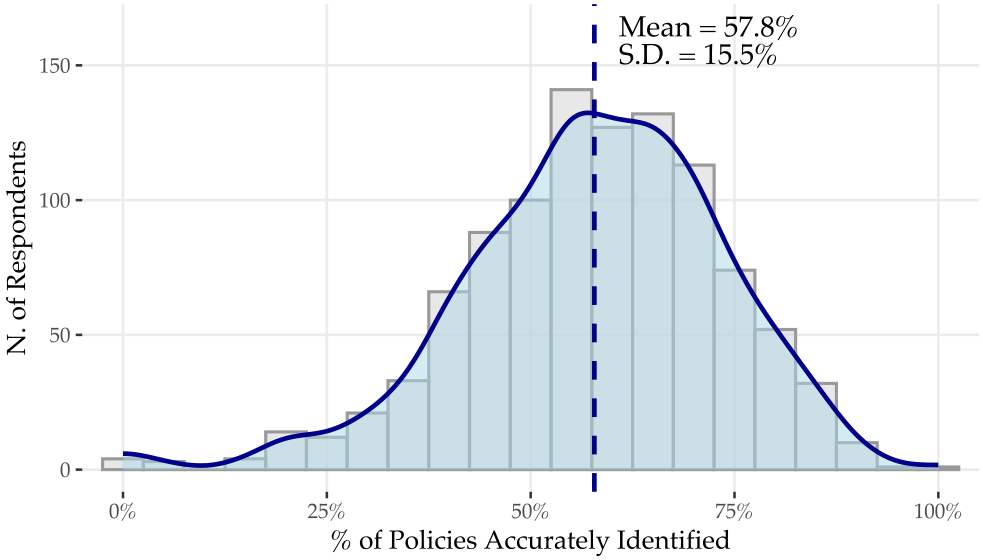
The analysis proceeds in three stages. The first documents how accurately respondents identify the policy decisions of their city governments. The second assesses whether applying partisan heuristics helps respondents appear more knowledgeable about city policy. The third examines whether individuals' knowledge of the policy decisions of their city governments is sufficient to properly punish or reward local politicians according to their preferences.

Knowledge About Local Policy

Respondents accurately identified the policy decisions of their city governments related to the twenty policies in question 57.8% of the time on average (st. dev. = 15.5%), or about 11.6 out of 20 policies. Figure 1 visualizes the distribution of the percentage of policy questions respondents answered correctly. Few respondents appear to be either highly knowledgeable or almost entirely uninformed.[5]

[5]Figure A.3 in Section A.4 of the Supplementary Information breaks the respondents into demographic subgroups to identify whether knowledge meaningfully varies by types of respondents. Nearly every respondent subgroup clusters between an average accuracy rate of 55% and 60% with frequently overlapping

Figure 1: Distribution of Policy Knowledge



To put this observed accuracy rate into perspective, consider three potential baselines.[6] First, imagine a respondent who flips an unbiased coin to determine their beliefs about whether each of the policies has been enacted in their city. This respondent's expected accuracy rate would be 50%. In reality, respondents outperform this random guessing baseline by 7.8 percentage points on average. Similarly, imagine a respondent who is not guessing at random, but instead selects the same option—"describes my city" or "does not describe my city"—for every question. Because, for most of the twenty policies, a majority of respondents live in cities where the policy is absent (see Table 2), a hypothetical respondent who thinks all twenty policies are present is expected to earn an accuracy rate of 42.7% while one who thinks all twenty policies are absent is expected to be accurate 57.3% of the time, a rate nearly identical to the observed sample mean. Lastly, if a respondent lacked specific knowledge of their own city's actions but possessed a general awareness of how frequently each of the twenty policies has been adopted nationwide, they could guess whether a policy is present in their city based on the probability they live

confidence intervals. Additionally, Figure A.4 in Section A.4 presents how respondents' level of accuracy varies by policy.

[6]The mathematical derivations for the expected average accuracy rates for all of these baselines are provided in Section A.3 of the Supplementary Information.

in a city where the policy is present. Using this strategy, a respondent's expected accuracy rate is 61.5%. In reality, respondents underperform this base enactment-rate benchmark by 3.7 percentage points.

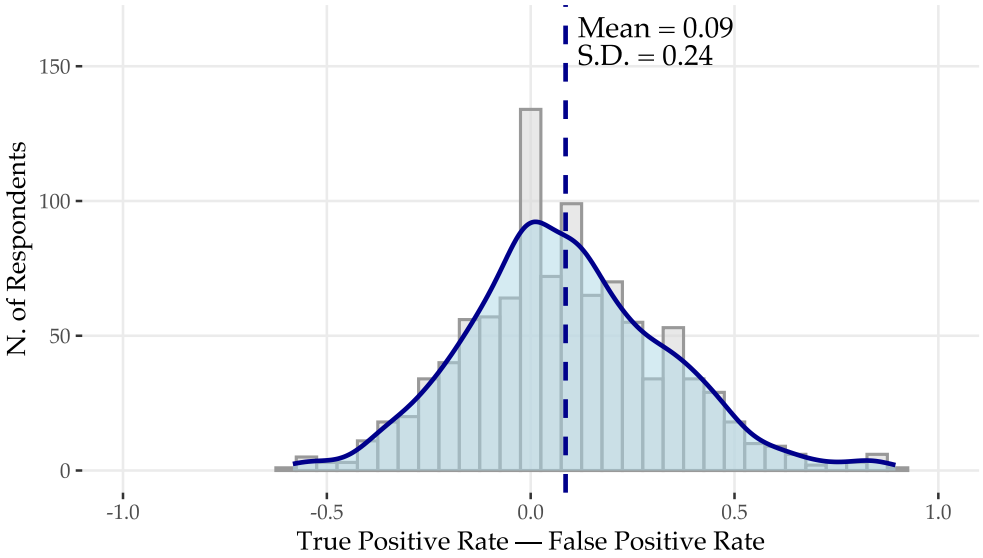
The observed mean's position between these three baselines suggests that respondents are not simply guessing at random, but they also fall short of the accuracy that a naive heuristic requiring no city-specific information could provide. Additionally, respondents' observed knowledge does not rise substantially above the knowledge a respondent who simply answers "no" for every policy question would be expected to exhibit. While residents possess enough local awareness to outperform a coin flip, they frequently assume their city has adopted policies it has not, or failed to adopt policies that exist. Of incorrect beliefs about city policy, 58.4% take the form of respondents believing their city has enacted a policy that it has not, indicating a bias toward over-assuming government action.

To further evaluate whether respondents' observed performance in identifying their cities' policies reflects genuine knowledge or is an artifact of response bias or policy prevalence nationwide, I calculate a net discrimination rate for each respondent.[7] This measure is calculated as $J = \text{TPR} - \text{FPR}$, representing the difference between the proportion of enacted policies a respondent correctly identifies (true positive rate) and the proportion of non-enacted policies they incorrectly claim exist (false positive rate). Figure 2 plots the distribution of individual net discrimination scores across the sample. The primary analytical strength of this metric is that uninformative response strategies—such as coin-flipping, defaulting to all-present or all-absent, or guessing based on national base enactment rates—yield an expected score of 0. Any positive score indicates genuine discrimination ability, whereas negative scores indicate systematic policy misunderstandings.

The sample's mean net discrimination score is 0.09 (s.d. = 0.24). After accounting for false positives, the average respondent's true positive rate exceeds their false positive rate by only 9 percentage points. Approximately 9.7% of respondents exhibit exactly

[7]The net discrimination rate measure mirrors Youden's J index for rating diagnostic tests, which is frequently employed in the cognitive psychology literature (Youden 1950; Stanislaw and Todorov 1999).

Figure 2: Distribution of Policy Net Discrimination
(Youden's J)



zero net discrimination, accounting for the prominent discrete spike at zero in Figure 2. These respondents' answers are consistent with non-informative guessing strategies. A majority of respondents (57.2%) display positive discrimination ability ($J > 0$), correctly identifying true policies at a higher rate than generating false positives. Strikingly, 33.1% of respondents register negative discrimination scores ($J < 0$), exhibiting a higher false positive rate than true positive rate by systematically reporting policy enactments that do not exist in their cities.

Collectively, these results point to limited and uneven local policy knowledge. The average respondent performs only modestly better than chance, achieving a true positive rate that exceeds their false positive rate by less than ten percentage points. While a majority of respondents display some genuine policy knowledge, roughly a third hold systematic misbeliefs about local policy that perform worse than uninformative guessing would in expectation.

Applying National Partisan Heuristics to Local Policy Does Not Make Voters Appear More Knowledgeable

As mentioned previously, prominent voices in the literature on voter knowledge maintain that voters do not need precise knowledge, but can employ cognitive shortcuts to appear as if they are genuinely informed. In U.S. politics, stereotypes related to the two national political parties are one such shortcut. Are voters capable of applying this heuristic to appear more knowledgeable about their cities' policies?

Even without knowing anything about their own city's policies, a voter could infer a policy's presence or absence if they know their city's partisan lean and which party is more strongly associated with that policy. At the same time, however, a voter misinformed about either the partisan lean of their city or the partisan character of a policy could be misled into making incorrect inferences. Below, I test whether partisan thinking leads voters to correct conclusions by first examining how often respondents are correct about the partisan tendencies of their cities and the city policies in question, and then by identifying if those who are correct about both of these cues are more likely to be correct in their beliefs about their cities' policy outputs.

Most respondents are capable of correctly identifying the partisan lean of their cities' electorates. About three-quarters of respondents (73.1%) could accurately identify whether more of their cities' voters supported the Democratic or Republican candidate for president in the 2024 general election. Of the 321 cities that respondents represent, majorities of voters supported Kamala Harris in 2024 in 230 cities, while majorities in 91 cities supported Donald Trump.

Table 4 compares the partisan pattern of policy adoption with respondents' beliefs about that pattern. Democratic cities adopt the twenty policies at an average rate of 35.2%, compared to 18.3% for Republican cities, a gap of 16.9 percentage points. For fifteen of the twenty policies, the adoption rate is at least 10 points higher in Democratic cities.

Respondents, however, are only modestly attuned to these partisan patterns. I con-

Table 4: Partisan Patterns in Policy Adoption and Public Perceptions of Policy Partisanship

Policy	Adoption Rate in Dem. Cities	Adoption Rate in Rep. Cities	Difference	Respondents Associating Policy w/ Dem. Cities	Respondents Associating Policy w/ Both Types of Cities	Respondents Associating Policy w/ Rep. Cities	Respondents Considered Correct About Party-Association
D.E.I. Initiative	50%	8.8%	41.2	72.4%	18.7%	8.9%	72.4%
Civilian Police Oversight Committee	43.5%	9.9%	33.6	59.1%	25.2%	15.4%	59.1%
LGBT Non-discrimination	53%	22%	31.1	62.1%	27%	10.6%	62.1%
Removal of Off Street Parking Minimums	49.6%	25.3%	24.3	26%	40%	33.8%	26%
Inclusionary Zoning	29.6%	5.5%	24.1	62.9%	25.7%	11%	62.9%
Climate Emergency Declaration	19.6%	0%	19.6	69.2%	20.3%	10.3%	69.2%
Mental Health Co-Responder	66.5%	47.3%	19.3	64.3%	24.8%	10.8%	64.3%
E-scooter/Bike Share	40.9%	22%	18.9	28.4%	46%	25.4%	28.4%
Zero Emission Fleet Plan	22.2%	3.3%	18.9	63.1%	24.6%	12.1%	63.1%
Housing First	36.1%	18.7%	17.4	62.2%	24.3%	13.2%	62.2%
Transit-Signal Priority/Bus Lanes	27%	9.9%	17.1	46.9%	39.6%	13.2%	46.9%
Homeless Response Unit	55.2%	39.6%	15.7	57.5%	28.6%	13.6%	57.5%
Anti-Displacement Assistance	16.5%	1.1%	15.4	62.5%	26.4%	10.8%	62.5%
Big Box Retailer Restrictions	15.7%	5.5%	10.2	46.3%	37.1%	16.3%	46.3%
E.V. Charger Incentives	26.5%	16.5%	10	57.9%	26.6%	15.2%	57.9%
Accessory Dwelling Unit	80%	70.3%	9.7	33.3%	44%	22.4%	44%
Just Cause Eviction	28.7%	22%	6.7	56.9%	29.1%	13.7%	29.1%
Police Demilitarization	8.7%	4.4%	4.3	67.6%	21.5%	10.6%	21.5%
Gender Neutral Language	3.5%	3.3%	0.2	66.9%	21.4%	11.5%	21.4%
"15-Minute City" Plan	30.4%	30.8%	-0.3	55.3%	34%	10.4%	34%
Mean	35.2%	18.3%	16.9	56%	29.2%	14.5%	49.5%

Note: City partisan lean is determined by aggregating precinct-level results from the 2024 presidential election to the city level. The "Difference" column is the adoption rate in Democratic cities minus the adoption rate in Republican cities, in percentage points. The final column reports the percentage of respondents whose stated party association matches the policy's actual association. A policy is classified as associated with Democratic (Republican) cities if its adoption rate is at least 10 percentage points higher in Democratic (Republican) cities. Respondents who associate such a policy with that party's cities are considered correct. Policies with an absolute difference in adoption rates of less than 10 percentage points are treated as equally likely to be enacted in both types of cities, and for these policies only respondents who select "both types of cities" are considered correct. For all other policies, selecting "both types of cities" is considered incorrect.

sider respondents correct about a policy's partisan association if they believe the policy is more likely to be enacted in Democratic cities and the difference in actual adoption rates between Democratic and Republican cities is greater than ten percentage points. For policies where this difference is less than ten percentage points, respondents who indicated they believe the policy is equally likely in Democratic and Republican cities are considered correct. Averaged across policies, only 49.5% of respondents correctly identify the partisan association of a policy. In other words, the typical respondent is about as likely to be wrong as right about which type of city adopts a given policy. Accuracy exceeds two-thirds for only two policies, D.E.I. initiatives (72.4%) and climate emergency declarations (69.2%). It falls below 30% for five policies, including the removal of off-street parking minimums (26.0%), which respondents are more likely to associate with Republican cities (33.8%) than with Democratic cities (26.0%), the opposite of the true pattern. Respondents' errors also tilt in a consistent direction. For the five policies with no meaningful partisan gap, just 21–44% of respondents correctly say the policy is equally likely in both

types of cities, and most instead assign policies such as police demilitarization (67.6%) and gender-neutral language (66.9%) to Democratic cities. The overarching implication is that most residents possess an accurate sense of the partisan lean of the city they live in, but a poorly calibrated sense of which party to associate with each policy.

When respondents do hold correct beliefs about the partisan nature of their cities and the policies in question, they are only slightly more likely to make correct inferences about their own cities' policies. Table 5 presents the results of a multilevel linear probability model that predicts correct beliefs about policies given respondents' understanding of the partisan lean of their cities and the policies in question while accounting for respondent- and policy-level random intercepts as well as an array of demographic political controls. Each observation is a respondent-policy pairing and coefficients can be interpreted as changes in the predicted probability of being correct about a given policy's presence or absence.

Table 5: The Minimal Effect of Correctly Associating Cities, Policies, and Parties on Accurately Identifying City Policy

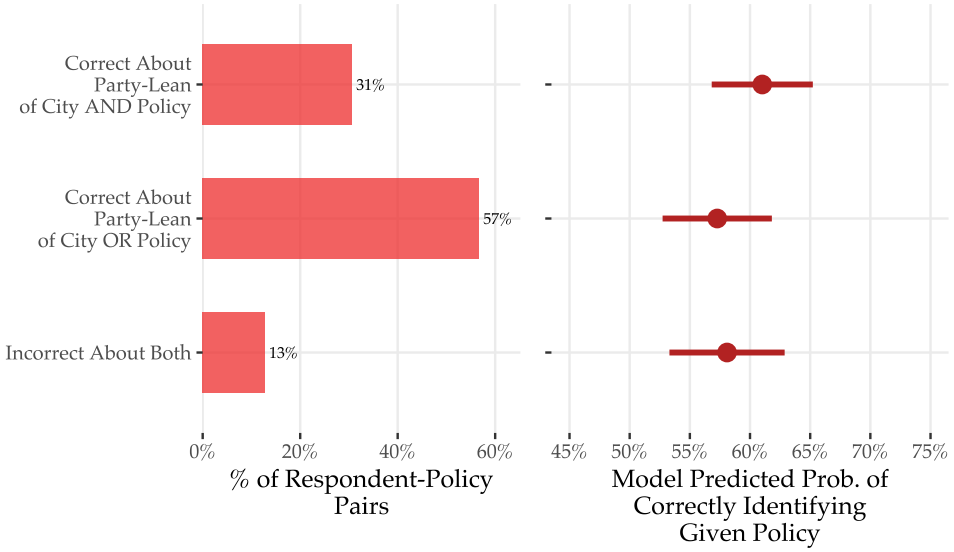
	D.V.: Correctly Identifying Given Policy = 1
	(1)
Correct About City Party-Lean	0.007
	(0.014)
Correct Association Between Policy and Party	-0.023
	(0.015)
Correct About City-Party × Correct about Policy-Party	0.046**
	(0.017)
Constant	0.520***
	(0.063)
Observations	17,037
R^2 Marg.	0.009
R^2 Cond.	0.059

Note: Estimates (with standard errors in parentheses) are derived from a multilevel linear probability model with random intercepts for each respondent and policy. The model also includes controls for respondents' partisanship, gender, age, education, sexuality, race/ethnicity, income, length of residency, work location, homeowner status, interest in political news, voter registration, and turnout in the most recent local election. *$p < 0.05$, **$p < 0.01$, ***$p < 0.001$.

Neither holding accurate knowledge of the city's partisan lean nor correctly under-

standing which party to associate with a given policy independently increases the probability of correct identification. The interaction term between these two indicators, however, is statistically significant and suggests respondents with correct understandings of both have a higher likelihood of correctly identifying their cities' policy. Figure 3 illustrates the substantive implications of these estimates by plotting the distribution of respondent-policy pairs against predicted probabilities of policy identification accuracy. Respondents who are incorrect about both are predicted to correctly identify policy only 58.1% of the time, compared to 57.3% for those correct about only one condition and 61% for those correct about both. Because the 95% confidence intervals across all three categories heavily overlap, these minor differences are substantively negligible.

Figure 3: Correct Partisan Associations With Cities and Policies Yield Negligible Improvements in the Likelihood of Correctly Identifying City Policy



Thus, while most respondents have a general sense of the partisan environment of the cities in which they live, their understanding of which political party to associate with which municipal policies is poorly calibrated with reality. In fewer than one-third of instances do respondents correctly identify both the partisan lean of their city *and* the partisan lean of the cities that are more likely to enact a policy in question, and being

correct about these reasoning inputs only translates to a minimal increase in the likelihood of correctly identifying the policy in one's city. The application of partisan heuristics, therefore, does not rescue voters from limited policy knowledge or make them appear properly informed.

Consequences for Accountability

Up to this point, the data establish that while most voters are better at correctly identifying their city governments' policy decisions than chance, their level of knowledge falls short of what normative theories of democracy might expect of them. Are voters capable of holding their city governments accountable for their policy decisions, given this low to moderate level of knowledge? For an individual voter to hold their government accountable for its policy decisions, we should expect them to reward policymakers and elected officials when policy aligns with their preferences and sanction them if not. To test whether this form of accountability occurs, I examine whether respondents are more likely to express greater satisfaction with their city governments and re-elect their incumbent mayor as the alignment between their preferences for policy and the actual policy decisions of their city government increases, all else equal. The models shown in the first column of both Tables 6 and 7 present the results of this test.

As city policy becomes more congruent with respondent preferences, respondents give moderately higher approval ratings to their city governments and are somewhat more likely to express a willingness to re-elect their incumbent mayor. A respondent whose preferences are congruent with their city's policy on all 20 policies is predicted to approve of their city government nearly a full point higher on the 7-point approval scale ($\Delta = 0.88$) and is more likely to express a willingness to re-elect their mayor by nearly 20 percentage points, compared to a respondent whose preferences are always incongruent with their city's policy. By themselves, these positive relationships indicate that individuals are capable of holding their city governments accountable for policy, as they tend to

Table 6: The Effect of Policy Congruence (Perceived & Actual) on City Government Approval

	D.V.: City Government Approval (1 – 7)				
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Actual Policy Congruence (-1 to 1)	0.443**	-0.101			0.024
	(0.160)	(0.159)			(0.134)
Perceptions of Policy Congruence (-1 to 1)		1.513***			0.871***
		(0.136)			(0.118)
Correct Perceptions of Policy Congruence			1.407***		
			(0.194)		
Incorrect Perceptions of Policy Congruence			1.681***		
			(0.263)		
Perceived Co-partisanship w/ Mayor (-1 to 1)				0.321***	0.258***
				(0.050)	(0.050)
Eval. of City Conditions (-1 to 1)				1.680***	1.557***
				(0.082)	(0.082)
Constant	4.116***	4.037***	4.054***	3.321***	3.422***
	(0.568)	(0.536)	(0.534)	(0.461)	(0.449)
Observations	1,019	1,019	1,019	1,016	1,016
R^2	0.089	0.191	0.195	0.408	0.443
Adj. R^2	0.050	0.155	0.159	0.382	0.417

Note: Estimates are derived from OLS regressions with standard errs in parentheses. All models include controls for respondents' partisanship, gender, age, education, sexuality, race/ethnicity, income, length of residents, work location, homeowner status, interest in political news, voter registration status, and turnout in the most recent local election. *$p < 0.05$, **$p < 0.01$, ***$p < 0.001$.

reward their officials when policy matches their preferences and tend to punish them if not.

But as has been demonstrated, respondents' beliefs about the policy actions of their cities are incorrect almost as often as they are correct. Frequently held incorrect beliefs about policy could distort voters' ability to properly reward or sanction officials according to their preferences. Take, for instance, a misinformed voter who believes their city has enacted a policy they prefer, but in reality no such policy has been enacted. This voter may reward local officials for this perceived policy action, even though policy is incongruent with their preferences in reality. The models presented in the second columns of Tables 6 and 7 test if individuals reward local officials more when they *think* they are getting the policies they want.

Table 7: The Effect of Policy Congruence (Perceived & Actual) on Willingness to Re-elect Incumbent Mayor

	D.V.: Would Re-Elect Incumbent = 1				
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Actual Policy Congruence (-1 to 1)	0.098*	-0.004			0.003
	(0.044)	(0.045)			(0.042)
Perceptions of Policy Congruence (-1 to 1)		0.285***			0.153***
		(0.038)			(0.037)
Correct Perceptions of Policy Congruence			0.282***		
			(0.055)		
Incorrect Perceptions of Policy Congruence			0.299***		
			(0.074)		
Perceived Co-partisanship w/ Mayor (-1 to 1)				0.103***	0.091***
				(0.015)	(0.016)
Eval. of City Conditions (-1 to 1)				0.297***	0.276***
				(0.025)	(0.025)
Constant	0.406**	0.389**	0.391**	0.210	0.227
	(0.155)	(0.151)	(0.150)	(0.141)	(0.140)
Observations	1,020	1,020	1,020	1,017	1,017
R^2	0.132	0.178	0.180	0.293	0.306
Adj. R^2	0.094	0.142	0.144	0.261	0.274

Note:
Estimates are derived from OLS regressions with standard errors in parentheses. All models include controls for respondents' partisanship, gender, age, education, sexuality, race/ethnicity, income, length of residents, work location, homeowner status, interest in political news, voter registration status, and turnout in the most recent local election. *$p < 0.05$, **$p < 0.01$, ***$p < 0.001$.

The coefficients for perceived policy congruence reveal that individuals' beliefs about the policy decisions of their city governments are decisively more strongly associated with their level of government approval and willingness to re-elect incumbent mayors than policy reality. A respondent who believes city policy always aligns with their preferences is expected to approve of their government 3.03 points higher on the 7-point approval scale and is more likely to re-elect their incumbent mayor by 53 percentage points. Once beliefs about policy are accounted for, the relationship between actual congruence and evaluations of government or willingness to re-elect incumbents is statistically indistinguishable from zero. In other words, individuals base their evaluations of local officials upon the conceptions of government actions that exist within their heads and not upon the bona fide policy decisions of city governments.

Policy accountability could persist despite individuals' evaluations of local officials resting on their beliefs about policy if those individuals place greater weight on their correct beliefs about policy than incorrect ones. The third column of Tables 6 and 7 reports the relationships of correct and incorrect perceptions of policy congruence with evaluations of local governments and officials. The results offer no support for the possibility that voters weigh correct beliefs differently than incorrect ones. Both correct and incorrect perceptions of policy congruence positively predict government approval (β = 1.41 and β = 1.68) and willingness to re-elect incumbents (β = 0.28 and β = 0.30). Linear hypothesis tests fail to reject the null hypotheses that the coefficients associated with correct and incorrect perceptions are equal to one another across both models (F = 0.54, p = 0.46 for the model predicting government approval and F = 0.03, p = 0.87 for the model predicting willingness to re-elect the incumbent). Functionally, the nearly identical coefficient magnitudes demonstrate that residents reward their city governments and officials when they believe policy is more aligned with their preferences regardless of whether those beliefs reflect reality. In other words, incorrect perceptions of congruence, which by definition are instances of actual incongruence, predict approval as strongly as correct perceptions.

A potential alternative explanation to account for these relationships is that perceptions of policy congruence are merely a proxy for other well-established predictors of government approval and vote choice. Beyond their beliefs about policy, voters hold broader assessments of conditions in their city that they may attribute to local officials. Those who view city conditions more positively may assume that their city's policies mirror their preferences, making the previously established relationships more of a product of their retrospective evaluations than understandings of city policy. In addition, perceptions of policy congruence may be inflated among those who believe they are co-partisans with their local officials because they assume those officials are more likely to share their preferences about policy. Thus it is conceivable that the effects of perceptions of policy congruence could be confounded by a sense of shared partisanship.

The fourth column of Tables 6 and 7 reports the relationships of both of these potential confounders with evaluations of governments and officials. Perceived co-partisanship with mayor is a measure that takes a value of 1 when a respondent believes their mayor shares their party affiliation (even in instances where the mayor is elected in an officially nonpartisan election), a value of 0 if the respondent is an independent or indicates they do not know their mayor's partisanship, and a value of -1 when the mayor is believed to be from the out-party. The measure for evaluations of city conditions comes from respondents' answers to a question asking whether they believe their city is a better or worse place to live now compared to a few years ago. Respondents indicated their response on a 1 to 7 scale, with higher values indicating their city is a better place to live. For ease of comparison with other coefficients, this measure is rescaled to a range of -1 to 1. The models confirm that both of these variables are associated with higher evaluations of local governments and willingness to re-elect incumbents. The association evaluations of city conditions is largest, predicting those with the most positive views of the conditions in their city will approve of their city government 3.36 points higher on the 7-point scale. By comparison, a respondent believing their mayor is a co-partisan is only predicted to approve of their government 0.64 points higher than one who believes their mayor is an out-partisan.

When incorporated into the same models (presented in the fifth column of Tables 6 and 7), perceptions of policy congruence have an independent explanatory association with city government approval and willingness to re-elect incumbents. The estimated relationship with perceptions of congruence is smaller than that of evaluations of city conditions, but more than three times as large as the that of perceived co-partisanship. Thus, perceptions of policy congruence are not merely an artifact of diffuse satisfaction with city conditions or partisan attachment. Residents' beliefs, correct and incorrect, about what policies their city governments have enacted, and not which policies those governments have actually enacted, help explain how they view their city governments and translate

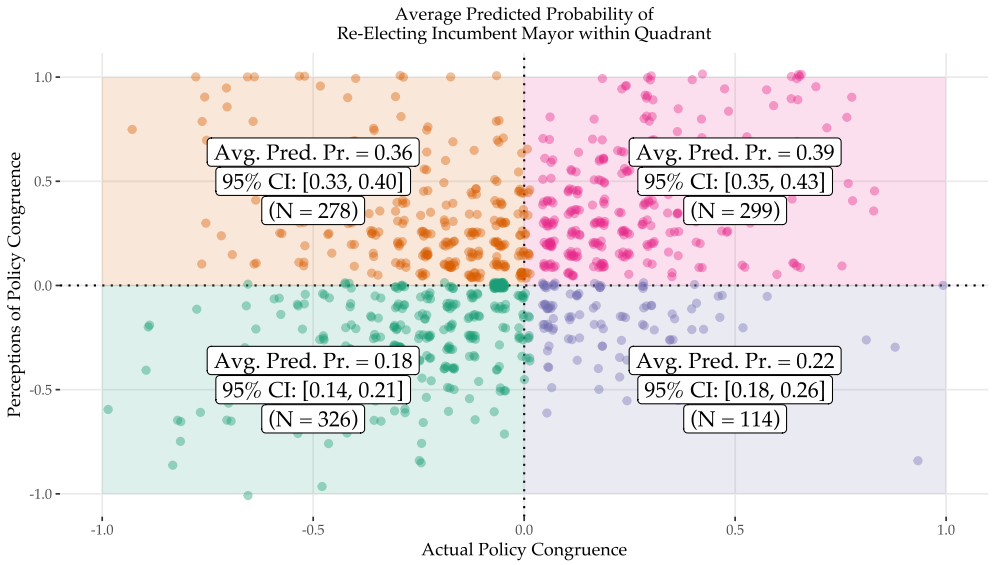
into their electoral decisions to punish or reward incumbent candidates.

To illustrate the substantive magnitude of these results, Figure 4 shows the average predicted probability of willingness to re-elect the incumbent mayor for respondents in each combination of positive or negative actual and perceptions of policy congruence.[8] Perceptions of congruence clearly separate the groups. Among respondents whose cities' policies are more often incongruent with their preferences, those who believe policy is more congruent are 19 percentage points more likely to support the incumbent than those who perceive incongruence (0.36 vs. 0.18; 95% C.I. of the difference being [0.15, 0.23]). The corresponding gap among respondents whose cities' policies are actually congruent with their preferences is 17 percentage points (0.39 vs. 0.22; 95% C.I. of the difference being [0.13, 0.21]). At the same time, moving from negative to positive actual policy congruence increases the likelihood of incumbent support by only 0.03 to 0.05, indicating that its association with predicted support is minuscule relative to that of perceptions. The key takeaway from this illustration is that respondents who perceive congruence when in reality policy is incongruent are predicted to reward incumbents at nearly the same rate as respondents who perceive congruence that experience congruence in reality, while those who perceive incongruence are far less supportive regardless of the level of correspondence between preferences and policy.

A skeptical reader might object that any of the relationships described here between beliefs about policy and evaluations of government could conceivably run in the opposite direction. In other words, residents who already approve of their city government may tend to assume in the absence of genuine policy knowledge that it is delivering the policies they want. The cross-sectional nature of these data cannot fully adjudicate the causal ordering of this relationship, although perceptions of policy congruence having an independent effect on government evaluations when also accounting for evaluations

[8] Because these quadrant boundaries are somewhat arbitrary, I present an additional Figure in Section A.6 of the Supplementary Information to illustrate that the interpretation of the results do not depend on the quadrant cutoffs.

Figure 4: Actual & Perceived Policy Congruence's Roles in Predicting Electoral Punishment/Reward



of city conditions may suggest that beliefs about policy congruence are not purely the consequence of projection. However, the ambiguity of whether perceived congruence or government evaluations come first does not resolve concerns about the health of local democratic accountability. If perceptions of policy congruence, and not reality, shape approval, then residents are rewarding and punishing their governments on the basis of frequently mistaken beliefs about policy reality. If, instead, approval shapes perceptions of policy congruence, then residents are not evaluating their governments on their policy decisions at all, but are manufacturing a sense of policy congruence to rationalize evaluations formed on other grounds. Either account describes a local accountability process in which the actual policy enacted by city governments does not directly influence how voters assess those governments.

Discussion

How much do voters know about the policy enacted by their city governments, and is that knowledge sufficient to hold local officials accountable for policy? By compiling a com-

prehensive account of standing city policy regarding 20 issues in hundreds of medium to large U.S. cities and linking it to an original survey of residents living in those cities, this paper establishes three connected findings. First, residents can accurately identify the policies enacted by their city governments only marginally better than chance, with errors skewing toward over-inferring government action. Second, applying partisan thinking to municipal policy does not make residents appear more knowledgeable because most hold poorly calibrated beliefs about which policies to associate with Democratic and Republican city governments. And third, when residents evaluate their city governments and elected officials, frequently incorrect beliefs about city policy influence those judgments more so than the city's actual policy decisions. A resident gives roughly similar weight to incorrect beliefs about their city's policy as they do to correct beliefs about their city's policy in forming political evaluations. In other words, individuals reward and punish city governments and elected officials for the policy record they imagine and not necessarily the one that exists.

With these results in mind, we can rule out a promising potential mechanism to explain the finding that municipal policy is cross-sectionally responsive to residents' ideology and partisan preferences (Tausanovitch and Warshaw 2014; Einstein and Kogan 2016). That results is often read as evidence that local democracy is working, at least on average. Despite informational constraints, city governments manage to track and respond to public opinion through policy reasonably well in the aggregate. But the mechanism through which aggregate responsiveness occurs remains underspecified (Tausanovitch 2019). The present findings work against the operation of an intuitive potential candidate—that individual voters monitor their specific government's policy record and reward or punish elected officials according to their policy preferences. Since voters' evaluations of city governments and local officials are predicted by routinely incorrect beliefs about city policy rather than direct observation of actual policy, individuals collectively holding officials accountable for policy is an unlikely candidate to explain aggregate responsible.

My results extend and reorient existing critiques of voters' ability to hold governments accountable. Achen and Bartels (2017) contend that voters punish and reward governments for circumstances that lie entirely outside of the control of elected officials, a failure of voter attribution. The failure documented here is of a different kind. Voters are not misattributring the causes of outcomes they observe, but evaluating governments based on policy records disconnected from reality. Voters are not punishing their mayor over forces outside of her control, but instead rewarding her for policy they agree with that has never been enacted.

These findings further complicate a literature that maintains democratic accountability can persist despite a widely uninformed electorate. Rather than substituting for genuine knowledge, the use of partisan shortcuts when perceiving local policy frequently does not meaningfully assist voters toward arriving at correct conclusions. In connection to the literature on local political behavior, Oliver and Ha (2007) find that a primary reason voters say they support local candidates is a sense of shared issue-positions. However, if voters systematically misperceive the policy actions of their city governments and reward or punish based on those perceptions, then the issue agreement that survey respondents report between themselves and preferred local candidates may be largely constructed rather than real.

That voters evaluate their local governments in this manner carries potentially troubling implications for the behavior of local officials. Ashworth and Bueno De Mesquita (2014) document the degree to which elections incentivize effort on the part of politicians depends on whether effort is observable and rewarded by voters. Because voters evaluate local governments based on their often unfounded beliefs about policy, actual policy performance becomes largely decoupled from electoral reward. The potentially optimal strategy for a local official may therefore be less about governance than it is about signaling in ways that voters can readily perceive. Future research should address whether visible symbolic choices or the language with which local issues are framed by local of-

ficials yield greater electoral returns than the substantive but largely invisible work of policymaking.

Taken together, these findings give empirical grounding to concerns raised about some of the political consequences of the nationalization of American politics. Hopkins (2018) argues that the diverting of attention from local to national concerns leads voters to judge local candidates, issues, and governments through the lens of national partisan competition. This shift, he claims, could lead to a deterioration in voters' capacity to evaluate local governments on their own terms. Indeed, the present findings identify that voters' knowledge of their cities' policy lags behind their knowledge of the actions of their federal legislators (for instance, see Ansolabehere and Kuriwaki 2022). The result is a status quo in which electoral rewards and punishments are governed more by misperceptions about policy rather than by the actual policy record of the governments voters are ostensibly evaluating.

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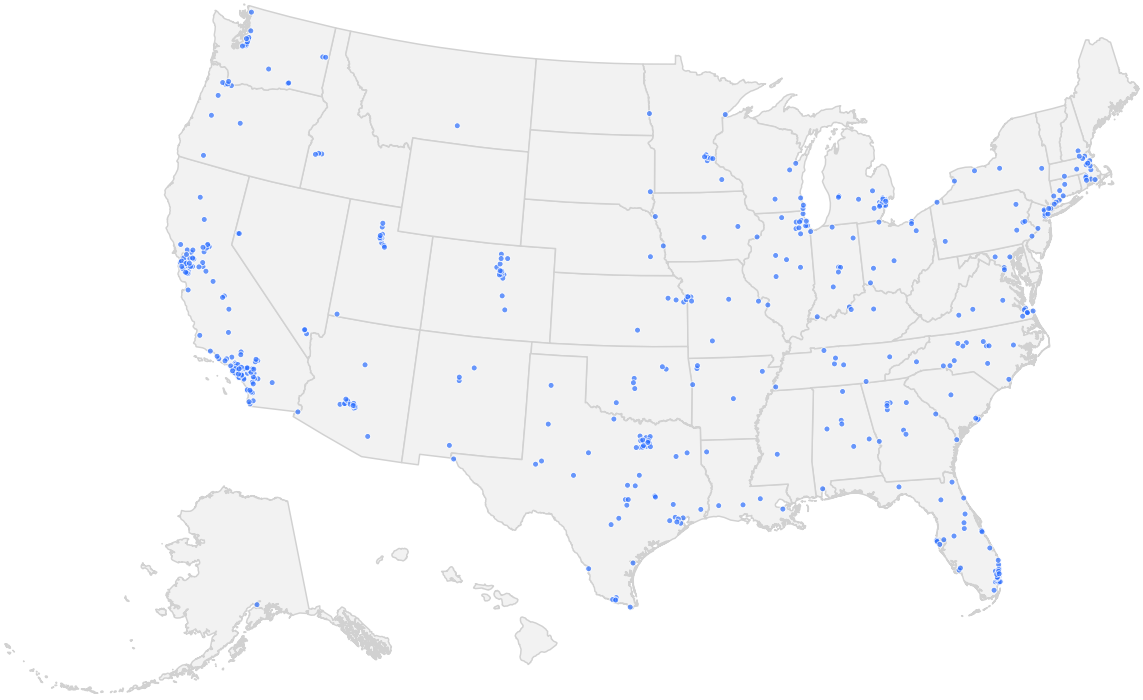
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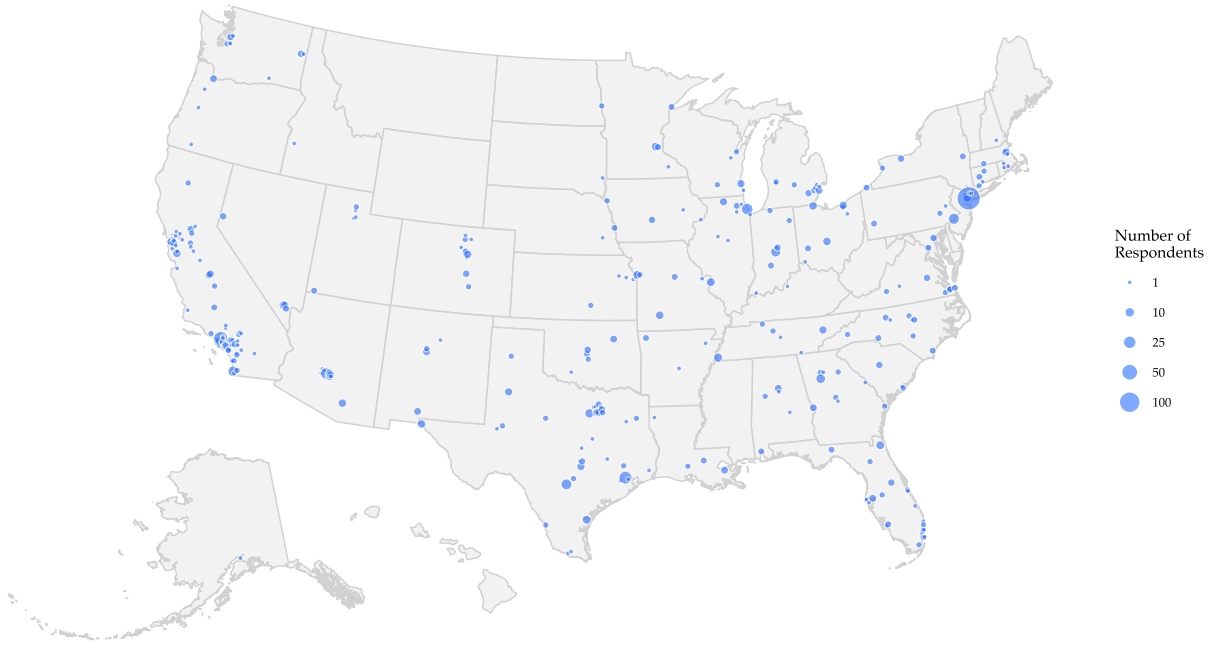
A.1 Cities Covered by Policy Data and Survey Sample

Figure A.1: Map of 484 Cities Included in Policy Data



Note: These are every U.S. municipality with a population greater than 75,000 residents as of the 2020 U.S. Census.

Figure A.2: Map of the Cities Represented by Survey Respondents



Note: Respondents live in 321 of the 484 cities in the sampling frame. Points on the map are sized according to the number of respondents in the sample from each city.

A.2 Policy Data Gathering Procedure

Information on the policymaking history of every U.S. municipality with a population above 75,000 residents was first gathered through an automated search procedure using GPT-5's web-search capability accessed through the OpenAI API. The web-search tool allows the model to search through up-to-date information on the internet rather than rely on its training data. The agent was provided with a set of specific instructions and produced answers accompanied by detailed citation information information. As such, it served more as a research assistant than an autonomous classifier.

Each query instructed the model to search for documented evidence of policy adoption, amendment, repeal, state government preemption, and/or court invalidation in a given city over time for a given policy based on a detailed definition of each policy domain. Below is the standardized prompt given to GPT-5 for each query.

*You are assisting with the **Municipal Policy History Project**. The goal is to compile an auditable history of policymaking in a single U.S. city. For the batch of policies specified below, conduct a real-time internet search to document all known relevant actions by the city government in [CITY], [STATE] ([PLACEFIPS] as Place FIPS, [STATEFIPS] as State FIPS) relevant to these policies*
REQUIRED OUTPUT FORMAT
Your entire response must consist only of pipe-delimited CSV output. Each row in the output will correspond to one policy action

- *No markdown tables, no code blocks, no additional text before or after the pipe-delimited CSV output.*

HEADER FORMATTING
*The first line of your output must be **EXACTLY** this header (pipe-delimited, no extra spaces): City—State—Policy Code—Policy Area—Year—Action—Value—Ordinance Number—Source URL—Continuous Measure Notes—Categorical Measure Notes—Other Notes—Place FIPS—State FIPS*
CODING AND FORMATTING RULES

- ***Only return the complete table. No other text or code blocks***
- ***Each row represents a single action for a single policy. Do not summarize or merge multiple actions into one row***
- ***Include every knowable action for each policy, as far back in time as the records allow***
- *City: Capitalize first letters (e.g., "San Jose")*
- *State: 2-letter USPS code (e.g., "CA")*

- *Place FIPS (5-digit) and State FIPS (2-digit): Enclose in parentheses (e.g., (061340) and (04)), preserve leading zeroes*
- *Year: Four-digit (YYYY), leave blank only when Action = "Absent"*
- *Action: Must be one of Enacted, Amended, Repealed, Pre-empted, Court Invalidated, Absent as defined:*
  - *"Enacted": First-time adoption*
  - *"Amended": Policy modified such that values in Continuous Measure Notes and/or Categorical Measure Notes column(s) will change*
  - *"Repealed": Policy rescinded/sunset*
  - *"Pre-empted": State override or standardized rule*
  - *"Court Invalidated": Court nullifies city policy*
  - *"Absent": No evidence policy ever existed*
- *Value: "1" if policy is or remains in effect post-action, "0" for repeal, invalidation, absence, etc.*
- *Ordinance Number: Official ordinance/resolution/order ID or title. If only media documentation exists or no official ID, write "MEDIA" and provide the corroborating URL. Must not be blank if Action = "Enacted", "Amended", or "Repealed"*
- *Source URL: Full canonical link to the city or official document; prioritize links directly to policy documents and never shorten links*
- *Continuous Measure Notes and Categorical Measure Notes: Complete as specified by the definition of the policy below for each action; if definition does not specify what to enter, leave column blank*
- *Other Notes: Succinct coding rationale (max 50 words), no long quotes/excepts. Always fill in, even when Action = "Absent".*
- *If you find evidence of multiple actions in one of the policy by the city over time, include each action as its own row, listing actions in chronological order by year (oldest first); if multiple actions occur in one year, order sequentially within the year*
- *Do not mix chronological ordering across different policies*
- *If prioritized sources yield no evidence of policymaking on an issue, set Action = "Absent", Value = "0", and leave Year/Ordinance Number/Source URL and Notes columns blank*

SOURCE PRIORITIZATION (SEARCH ORDER)
Official city sources (charter, code, ordinances/resolutions, council minutes, executive orders, city publications/program websites) → reputable local media or policy advocacy organizations → general internet search

- *When conducting the search, only examine the top 1 to 5 most relevant sources*

HALLUCINATION CONTROL

- *When multiple policies are included in the batch below, treat each policy as fully independent; do not use evidence from one policy to infer actions for another*
- *Any Action except "Absent" **must** cite a direct source URL*
- *For every "Amended" or "Repealed" row, there must be a preceding "Enacted" row for the same policy*
- *If no primary source is available, enter "MEDIA" in the Ordinance Number and a reputable media link in Source URL*

- *Never invent evidence; if not confident, record "Absent" and clarify in Other Notes if necessary*
- *If the policy is covered by multiple ordinances or concurrent actions, enter as separate chronologically ordered rows*
- *For each policy listed, only include actions relevant to that specific policy — Maintain strict separation of policies: sources, ordinance numbers, years, and notes must correspond exclusively to the policy code indicated in that row*

VERBOSITY

- *Output just the required table, *noting else*, matching the exact format and instructions above*
- *No apologies, summaries, or extraneous text*
- *Each row in the CSV must correspond to a single policy action for a single policy. Do not combine multiple actions or multiple policies into one row*
- *At least one row (even if Action = "Absent") is mandatory*

Each of the twenty policy issues was defined for the model as follows.

Environmental Sustainability

Climate Emergency Declaration

Has [CITY], [STATE] declared a climate emergency by resolution?

A climate emergency resolution is a resolution approved by the city's governing body that explicitly declares a climate emergency or crisis, recognizes climate change as an urgent threat, and calls for accelerated or emergency climate action. These declarations serve as a formal political commitment, without typically including any specific policy action. These are usually titled "Climate Emergency Resolution" or "Climate Crisis Declaration."

Do not include climate action plans or codified sustainability strategies or proclamations that do not explicitly declare an emergency or crisis.

E.V. Charger Incentives

Does [CITY], [STATE] offer incentives for the construction of electric vehicle charging infrastructure?

An electric vehicle infrastructure policy is any city ordinance, code, or program that formally supports, incentivizes, or mandates the construction or installation of EV charging infrastructure through financial incentives, regulatory measures, or coordinated city initiatives. This includes direct rebates, tax benefits, and zoning/building code requirements that encourage or require EV charger deployment.

Zero Emission Fleet Plan

Has [CITY], [STATE] adopted a Zero Emission Fleet Plan/Goal?

A zero emission fleet goal policy is an ordinance, resolution, or formally adopted plan that establishes a clear commitment, requirement, or target year for the city to transition some or all of its government-owned vehicles (fleet) to zero emission vehicles (ZEVs)—typically electric, hydrogen, or other vehicles that do not emit greenhouse gases or criteria pollutants.

Do not include general sustainability or climate plans that mention fleet electrification as an aspiration but do not set clear targets, timelines, or formal requirements, voluntary initiatives or internal reports not formally adopted by the governing body, or policies focused only on the procurement of low-emission (not zero-emission) vehicles or hybrids.

Housing & Homelessness

Anti-Displacement Assistance

Does [CITY], [STATE] provide financial relocation aid for those displaced during redevelopment or no-fault eviction?

An anti-displacement protection policy is any legislation or formal policy that requires landlords or developers to provide monetary relocation assistance to tenants displaced through no-fault evictions, such as eviction for owner move-in, condominium conversion, demolition, or compliance with government orders. These policies often define the amount or formula for relocation payments and/or require landlords to file declarations or applications with a city housing department before eviction notice and provide relocation payments within a set timeframe. Note: these policies are often included as part of a larger local rent stabilization ordinance or tenant protection ordinance.

Do not count general affordable housing programs that do not include tenant financial relocation components or voluntary relocation assistance without legal requirement.

Homeless Response Unit

Does [CITY], [STATE] have an administrative unit for coordinating homelessness response?

A homelessness response unit is an administrative unit, entity, or office created by formal city governmental action that coordinates response to homelessness within the city. The administrative unit typically has responsibility for overseeing and coordinating homelessness programs, services, and strategy at the city level.

Do not count informal committees or advisory groups without official authority or staffing, one-time task forces with no ongoing responsibility or administrative infrastructure, units established at the state or county level, or external nonprofit groups not officially part of the city government.

Housing First

Has [CITY], [STATE] enacted a "housing first"-type homelessness response strategy?

"Housing First" refers to a framework to responding to homelessness where cities prioritize providing permanent housing as quickly as possible to people experiencing homelessness, without preconditions such as sobriety, treatment participation, or housing "readiness." These strategies ensure access to safe, decent, and stable housing without barriers related to substance use, criminal history (unrelated to tenancy), or other traditional program requirements.

Count a city policy as Housing First if a city-adopted or otherwise reputable source—ordinance, resolution, executive order, administrative policy/manual, city program NOFA/guidelines, local journalism, professional policy brief—either explicitly states the city uses a "Housing First" approach or commits to placing people into permanent housing as quickly as possible without preconditions (no sobriety, treatment, or program-participation requirements) without using the "Housing First" moniker. Do not include targeted federal programs through HUD or state programs or county/CoC-only documents. Focus only on those carried out by the city government.

Do not count city participation in regional (county- or CoC-led) homelessness programs unless the city has formally opted into these initiatives through a legislative or administrative act (e.g., adopting a resolution, executing an MOU, or embedding Housing First standards into city programs or contracts).

Just Cause Eviction

Has [CITY], [STATE] enacted a "Just Cause" eviction policy?

A "Just Cause" eviction ordinance is any legislation or formal policy that requires landlords to have a legally valid reason ("just cause") to evict tenants after a specified period of tenancy, protecting tenants from arbitrary or no-fault evictions. These policies typically define allowable eviction causes including "at-fault" reasons (failure to pay rent, lease violations, illegal activity, damage to property) and "no-fault" reasons (landlord moving in, property removal from rental market, demolition or major renovation, government eminent domain actions). They also typically set applicability criteria based on tenant tenure and types of properties included or exempted. Note: these policies are often included as part of a larger local rent stabilization ordinance or tenant protection ordinance.

Inclusivity

D.E.I. Initiative

Has [CITY], [STATE] established a Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion (DEI) initiative?

A Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion (DEI) initiative is any formal legislation or adopted program that creates structured and possibly funded mechanisms for advancing diversity, equity, and inclusion at the municipal government level. This includes offices, commissions, strategic plans, training mandates, and leadership roles explicitly dedicated to DEI.

Do not include general diversity or inclusion statements without formal policy adoption or enforcement, informal DEI advisory groups without a legislative or executive mandate, or voluntary or non-binding initiatives lacking formal structure or accountability.

Gender Neutral Language

Does [CITY], [STATE] have a policy or guidelines that require gender-neutral language in official documents?

A gender-neutral language policy is any ordinance, charter amendment, or established set of administrative guidelines that explicitly mandates or implements the use of gender-neutral or gender-inclusive language throughout official city laws, codes, documents, and forms. These include changes to language from "fireman" to "firefighter," for instance.

Do not include general diversity or inclusion statements or policies limited solely to non-discrimination on the basis of gender identity or sexual orientation, unless they specifically mention recommended or required gender-neutral language use.

LGBT Non-discrimination

Has [CITY], [STATE] passed a non-discrimination policy covering sexual orientation and gender identity?

A non-discrimination policy is an officially adopted city ordinance that explicitly prohibits discrimination based on sexual orientation and/or gender identity across any of the relevant domains: employment, housing, and/or public accommodations. These policies will explicitly list sexual orientation and/or gender identity among protected categories. They will also have mechanisms whereby the policy will be enforced at the local level.

Do not include general diversity, equity, or inclusion statements or policies without explicit non-discrimination clauses or legal enforcement, non-binding resolutions that do not create enforceable rights or prohibitions, or state/federal laws not locally adopted or enforced by the city.

Land Use & Zoning

Accessory Dwelling Unit

Does [CITY], [STATE] allow accessory dwelling units (ADUs) in residential zones?

Accessory dwelling unit (ADU) policies are any legislation or formal regulations that permit the development of accessory dwelling units (ADUs) as secondary residential units on the same lot or parcel as a primary residence in designated residential zoning districts. These policies define what is considered as an ADU to the city, typically as a self-contained living unit with permanent provisions for sleeping, cooking, eating, and sanitation that are either attached or detached but on the same lot as the primary dwelling.

Do not count informal neighborhood guidelines or pilot programs without formal zoning or permitting standards.

Big Box Retailer Restrictions

Does [CITY], [STATE] limit, restrict, or ban the establishment of big-box retailers in commercial areas?"

Consider the policy as enacted if a city-adopted land use action explicitly restricts large-format retail via at least one of the following: (1) maximum floor-area thresholds for retail uses; (2) prohibitions or special limits on "superstores," "discount superstores," or "membership warehouses"; (3) conditional use permit (CUP) or equivalent discretionary approval uniquely triggered by large-format retail; (4) caps on the percentage of floor area for nontaxable goods (groceries) within large-format general merchandise;

or (5) a time-limited moratorium adopted to study or enact any of the above.
Do not include general zoning that incidentally discourages large stores (e.g., through height limits) without an explicit size/use trigger for large-format retail, economic impact studies not adopted with binding criteria, development agreements that do not create citywide rules, or county/state policies not specifically adopted by the city government.

Inclusionary Zoning
Has [CITY], [STATE] enacted an inclusionary zoning policy?
An inclusionary zoning policy is any formal ordinance, zoning code amendment, or otherwise official policy that requires or incentivizes developers to set aside a specified percentage of newly built residential units as affordable for low- or moderate-income households, usually within market-rate projects. These ordinances establish clear standards for affordability (income levels served), the percentage of required affordable units, and the duration of affordability restrictions. These policies often specify whether affordable units must be built on-site, nearby, or if developers may pay a fee in lieu of construction to support off-site affordable housing, allow for alternative compliance, offer density bonuses or other incentives for compliance, identify which developments the ordinance applies to, and/or specify development standards. These policies might apply to certain areas of the city, certain developments, or citywide.
Do not count informal incentives, programs without binding requirements, or affordable housing mandates not tied to new development or land use controls. Also, do not include legislation or policy established at the state or county level.

Policing
Civilian Police Oversight Committee
Does [CITY], [STATE] have a civilian police oversight board?
A civilian police oversight board policy is any city-adopted law, ordinance, charter chapter, or formal resolution that creates a formal civilian oversight board, commission, or committee with authority over the local police department aimed at increasing transparency, accountability, and community trust. These policies will define the board's composition, powers and responsibilities, authorities for conducting investigations or audits, and relationship with police departments and the city council.

Mental Health Co-Responder
Has [CITY], [STATE] implemented a co-responder program that pairs police with mental health professionals?
A co-responder program policy pairs police with mental health professionals by creating or authorizing programs where behavioral health specialists, clinicians, or social workers respond jointly with police officers to calls involving mental health crises or substance use issues. These programs specify that mental health professionals accompany law enforcement during crisis response shifts, with the goal to de-escalate crises, provide on-scene assessments, connect individuals to behavioral health services, and reduce arrests and emergency hospitalizations. These programs are different from crisis intervention team (CIT) programs, so be sure not to include a city's crisis intervention team here.
Do not include programs that were instituted or are administered at the county level.

Police Demilitarization
Has [CITY], [STATE] adopted a plan to demilitarize its police force?
A police demilitarization plan is any formal plan, law, ordinance, resolution, department directive, or budget provision specifically designed to prohibit, limit, or regulate the acquisition, deployment, or use of military-grade equipment and weapons by the police department. This includes policies that do any of the following: prohibit or restrict categories of military equipment such as armored vehicles, assault rifles, projectile launchers, tear gas, flashing grenades, and chemical agents, require the return disposal, or non-requisition of military equipment, establish guidelines or restrictions on the tactical deployment of such equipment, including bans during protests or in routine policing, and/or mandate transparency.

Transit Infrastructure

"15 Minute City" Plan

Has [CITY], [STATE] adopted an official "15-minute city" or walkability plan?

A 15-minute city or walkability plan is any city-adopted official plan, ordinance, or comprehensive strategies that aim to ensure residents can access most daily necessities like groceries, schools, parks, healthcare, transit, and services within a 15-20 minute walk or bike ride from their homes. These types of plans explicitly adopt goals or standards targeting walkability, bikeability, reduced car dependency, and local access equity. Include any such plans that incorporate these aims, even if they do not use the "15-minute city" title.

E-scooter/Bike Share

Has [CITY], [STATE] formally authorized, regulated, or funded a e-scooter or bike share program through government action?

A e-scooter or bike share program is any city-adopted ordinance, resolution, regulatory framework, contract, procurement policy, or officially adopted program that establishes the authorization and ongoing regulation or funding of a public or private e-scooter/bike share system operating within city boundaries. This includes the establishment of a permit or licensing system for private e-scooter/bike share operators, regulations covering safety standards, equipment requirements, service areas, and/or the creation or operation of a public bike share system or public-private partnership for bike share deployment.

Sources to find information on these programs include municipal code, council legislation databases, city transportation department webpages, formal contracts, and official bike share program documentation published by the city. Exclude informal proposals, community or advocacy group plans.

Removal of Off-street Parking Minimums

Has [CITY], [STATE] enacted a policy that removes minimum off-street parking requirements?

A policy that removes minimum off-street parking requirements is any ordinance, zoning code amendment, or comprehensive plan change that eliminates or significantly reduces the mandatory minimum number of off-street parking spaces that developers must provide for residential, commercial, or mixed-use developments. These policies allow developers to decide the amount of parking based on market demand or neighborhood context rather than fixed minimum parking ratios. Policies may include exemptions for parking requirements near high-quality public transit stops or within certain areas of the city.

Transit Signal Priority/Bus Lanes

Has [CITY], [STATE] implemented transit signal priority or transit lanes?

A transit signal priority (TSP) or transit lane policy is any city government-adopted ordinance, resolution, administrative policy, capital improvement plan, transit plan, or procurement authorization that formally authorizes or fund the deployment of transit signal priority (TSP) systems or dedicated transit lanes. TSP involves technologies or signal timing adjustment math extend green or shorten red signals for transit vehicles such as buses or streetcars at signalized intersections to reduce delays.

Policies that establish bus-only lanes, Bus Rapid Transit corridors, or queue jump lanes that provide exclusive or preferential right-of-way for transit vehicles should be included as a Transit Signal Priority Lanes policy.

Exclude informal planning documents or aspirational statements not formally adopted by the city government, as well as any county or regional policies not adopted or codified by the city government.

The model's search behavior was constrained to follow a source-prioritization rule designed to approximate conventional internet-based research practices. It was instructed to rely first on official city materials (e.g., codebooks, charter provisions, ordinances,

council resolutions, council minutes, executive orders, voter-approved initiatives, and official program documentation). If such documentation was incomplete or unavailable, the model was instructed to consult reputable local news outlets, followed by policy advocacy organizations, and finally only to conduct a broader web search once the prioritized sources were exhausted. For each identified government action, the prompt required the model to produce detailed citation information: a policy title, ordinance/resolution/code number, citation to a relevant section or city code, or reference to a credible secondary source, along with the dat the action took place and a working URL.

A team of trained human researchers audited model-generated data entries to assess their accuracy on completeness. First, the team targeted entries with missing or broken URLs, vague or incomplete citation information, anomalous adoption dates, and policy actions that appeared inconsistent with the broader political or legal context of the city in question. After which, the team verified the results from a random selection of about 10% of data entries to generate an unbiased baseline estimate of model accuracy across the full dataset. For each audited entry, researchers examined the linked sources, verified citation accuracy, confirmed the classification and timing of the reported policy action, and conducted their own internet searches to catch any omitted actions. When errors were identified, records were corrected.

It bears noting that omissions in the data are most likely to occur in cities with thinner internet and archival footprints, such as smaller or less wealthy municipalities with fewer digitized records. More broadly, the database is necessarily bounded by what is publicly documents and discoverable online. Policy actions that were never digitized, that exist only in physical municipal archives, or that predate the widespread availability of online municipal records may go undetected regardless of the thoroughness of the search procedure. This is a limitation shared by virtually any large-scale systematic effort to compile information on municipal governments over the internet, and it is one

that targeted auditing alone cannot fully resolve. That said, this dataset represents a substantial advance over what has previously been available to researchers. No existing resource compiles comparable policy histories across so many cities with this level of citation documentation.

A.3 Calculating Baseline Rates for Comparison

To conceptualize the observed accuracy rate among respondents of 57.8%, the paper compares this rate to a number of baselines that depict an expected accuracy rate under a set of different assumptions about respondents' response tendencies. Each expected accuracy rate is derived by setting the probability that a respondent guesses "Describes my city" for a given policy i (defined as q_i) relative to the true proportion of respondents living in a city where policy i is present (p_i). Across all baselines, the probability of a correct answer for any single policy i is given by:

$$P(Correct_i) = q_i \times p_i + (1 - q_i) \times (1 - p_i)$$

Averaging across $K = 20$ policies yields the overall expected baseline accuracy:

$$\bar{P}(Correct) = \frac{1}{K} \sum_{i=1}^{K} P(Correct_i)$$

The mathematical derivations for each of the comparison baseline rates are outlined below.

Pure 50/50 Coin Flip

Here, assume that the respondent guesses "Describes my city" with $q_i = 0.5$ for every policy.

$$\begin{aligned} P(Correct_i) &= 0.5 \times p_i + (1 - 0.5) \times (1 - p_i) \\ &= 0.5p_i + 0.5 - 0.5p_i \\ &= 0.5 \end{aligned}$$

Because p_i cancels out algebraically, pure coin-flipping always yields 50% accuracy in expectation regardless of actual policy prevalence.

Always Guessing "Does not describe my city"

Here, assume the respondent does not believe their local government acts on any of these policy issues such that $q_i = 0$ in every case.

$$\begin{aligned} P(Correct_i) &= 0 \times p_i + (1 - 0) \times (1 - p_i) \\ &= 1 - p_i \end{aligned}$$

As a consequence, the overall accuracy is $1 - \bar{p}$. Since the mean prevalence across all 20 policies among respondents in my sample is 42.7%, the expected accuracy under this baseline is 57.3%

Policy-Specific Base-Rate Guessing

Here, assume that the respondent does not have any city-specific information, but knows how common each individual policy is nationally. Thus, the rate at which the respondent says "Describes my city" is equal to the probability the respondent lives in a city with that policy ($q_i = p_i$)

$$P(Correct_i) = p_i^2 + (1 - p_i)^2$$

A.4 Knowledge by Demographic Sub-group and by Policy

Knowledge of city policy is strikingly uniform across demographic groups, as illustrated by Figure A.3. Nearly every respondent subgroup clusters between a mean accuracy rate of 55% and 60% with frequently overlapping confidence intervals. Respondents who follow public affairs closely, have higher incomes, or identify as non-Hispanic white tend to be marginally more accurate in their perceptions. But, these differences are modest, equating to correctly identifying less than one additional policy in each comparison. No noticeable differences in knowledge exist between respondents that have lived longer in their communities, work within their city's boundaries, own their home, or participate in local elections and those that do not. The lack of variation between these groups suggests that local embeddedness does not translate into higher levels of knowledge in regard to city policy.

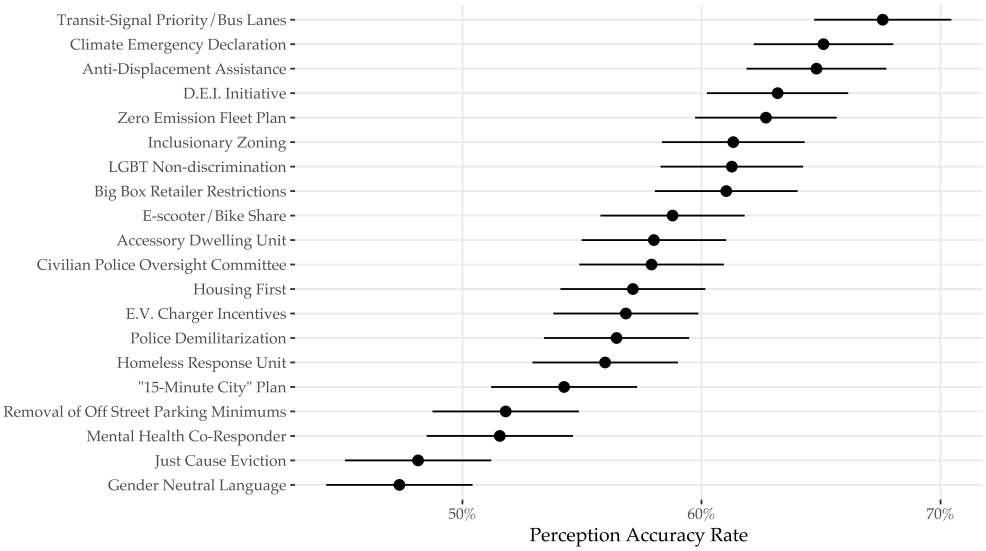
Figure A.3: Policy Identification Accuracy Across Demographic Groups



Figure A.4 orders each of the 20 policies according to the tendency of respondents to accuracy identify them within their city. The most frequently identified policy is transit-

signal priority/bus lanes, with the least frequent being a requirement to use gender neutral language in city documents. Because I only have twenty data points, I cannot identify with any confidence which "types" of policies respondents know more about. But, it is worth mentioning that the ability for respondents to identify policy accurately varies depending on the policy in question.

Figure A.4: Respondent Knowledge Accuracy, by Policy



A.5 Sensitivity of Results to the Inclusion and Exclusion of Certain Policies

A reasonable potential criticism of the findings presents in the paper is that they may be conditional on the selection of policies with which respondents were presented. In other words, if respondents gave their preferences and beliefs on smaller, larger, or a potentially different set of policies, the magnitude, direction, or statistical significance of the main estimates may differ. To address this concern, I run a set of sensitivity analyses that exclude one or a group of policies from the data and recalculate some of the primary quantities of interest. Taken the together, the results of these sensitivity tests suggest that I would arrive at estimates of similar magnitudes, directions, and statistical significance no matter the selection of policies to which respondents gave their preferences and beliefs.

In Table A.1, I present the estimated mean accuracy rate (Figure 1 in the main text), the interaction coefficient on partisan perceptions (Table 5 in main text), and the coefficients from the fully specified linear models that predict government approval and re-election intentions (Table 6 & Table 7 in main text) when each of the 20 policies is excluded from the data. The results demonstrate that leaving any one of the policies out does not impact the magnitude, direction, or statistical significance of any of the key estimates of interest.

Figures A.5 and A.6 extend these sensitivity analyses by presenting the estimates of interest calculated from 1,000 simulations that randomly drop five and ten of the policies from the analyses respectively. In each subplot, the simulations are arranged from the smallest to largest estimates across the x-axis. For reference, dashed lines in each subplot visualize the estimate presented in the main paper using all 20 policies, while dotted lines visualize those estimates' 95% confidence intervals.

Across both sets of simulations, the full-sample point estimates fall well within the

Table A.1: Replication of Main Results When Each Policy is Dropped from Analyses

Dropped Policy	Mean Accuracy Rate	City-Party x Policy-Party Interaction	A. Congruence Coef (Approval)	P. Congruence Coef (Approval)	A. Congruence Coef (Re-Elect)	P. Congruence Coef (Re-Elect)
Accessory Dwelling Unit	57.8%	0.046	0.007	0.869	0.007	0.147
	[57.0, 58.6]	[0.011, 0.081]	[-0.049, 0.064]	[0.820, 0.919]	[-0.011, 0.024]	[0.131, 0.162]
Anti-Displacement Assistance	57.5%	0.052	0.021	0.863	0.007	0.154
	[56.7, 58.3]	[0.018, 0.087]	[-0.035, 0.078]	[0.813, 0.914]	[-0.011, 0.025]	[0.138, 0.170]
Big Box Retailer Restrictions	57.7%	0.046	0.068	0.844	0.015	0.150
	[56.9, 58.5]	[0.011, 0.080]	[0.009, 0.127]	[0.794, 0.893]	[-0.003, 0.033]	[0.135, 0.166]
Civilian Police Oversight Committee	57.8%	0.044	-0.006	0.865	-0.012	0.152
	[57.0, 58.6]	[0.010, 0.079]	[-0.063, 0.051]	[0.815, 0.915]	[-0.030, 0.006]	[0.136, 0.168]
Climate Emergency Declaration	57.4%	0.049	0.009	0.892	0.006	0.149
	[56.6, 58.2]	[0.014, 0.084]	[-0.049, 0.066]	[0.842, 0.942]	[-0.012, 0.024]	[0.133, 0.164]
Mental Health Co-Responder	58.2%	0.037	0.006	0.883	-0.012	0.160
	[57.4, 59.0]	[0.002, 0.071]	[-0.053, 0.065]	[0.832, 0.933]	[-0.030, 0.006]	[0.144, 0.175]
D.E.I. Initiative	57.5%	0.042	-0.025	0.844	-0.010	0.145
	[56.7, 58.3]	[0.007, 0.077]	[-0.082, 0.032]	[0.794, 0.894]	[-0.028, 0.007]	[0.129, 0.160]
Police Demilitarization	57.9%	0.046	0.043	0.859	0.020	0.145
	[57.1, 58.7]	[0.011, 0.081]	[-0.012, 0.098]	[0.808, 0.910]	[0.002, 0.037]	[0.129, 0.161]
E.V. Charger Incentives	57.9%	0.044	0.048	0.861	0.012	0.156
	[57.1, 58.7]	[0.009, 0.079]	[-0.007, 0.103]	[0.811, 0.911]	[-0.006, 0.029]	[0.141, 0.172]
Housing First	57.9%	0.051	0.020	0.870	0.002	0.155
	[57.1, 58.7]	[0.016, 0.085]	[-0.039, 0.079]	[0.819, 0.920]	[-0.017, 0.020]	[0.139, 0.170]
Homeless Response Unit	57.9%	0.040	-0.008	0.849	-0.009	0.145
	[57.1, 58.7]	[0.005, 0.075]	[-0.065, 0.049]	[0.798, 0.899]	[-0.027, 0.009]	[0.129, 0.160]
Inclusionary Zoning	57.6%	0.047	0.029	0.866	-0.005	0.154
	[56.8, 58.4]	[0.012, 0.081]	[-0.029, 0.087]	[0.816, 0.916]	[-0.023, 0.013]	[0.138, 0.170]
Just Cause Eviction	58.3%	0.046	0.073	0.850	0.024	0.143
	[57.5, 59.1]	[0.011, 0.081]	[0.017, 0.129]	[0.799, 0.901]	[0.007, 0.042]	[0.127, 0.159]
Gender Neutral Language	58.4%	0.036	0.082	0.821	0.002	0.152
	[57.6, 59.2]	[0.001, 0.071]	[0.027, 0.138]	[0.771, 0.872]	[-0.015, 0.019]	[0.137, 0.168]
E-scooter/Bike Share	57.8%	0.057	-0.000	0.855	0.003	0.151
	[57.0, 58.6]	[0.022, 0.091]	[-0.055, 0.055]	[0.806, 0.905]	[-0.015, 0.020]	[0.136, 0.166]
"15-Minute City" Plan	58.0%	0.046	0.035	0.868	0.012	0.149
	[57.2, 58.8]	[0.011, 0.081]	[-0.021, 0.091]	[0.817, 0.918]	[-0.005, 0.030]	[0.133, 0.165]
LGBT Non-discrimination	57.6%	0.046	0.053	0.837	-0.000	0.152
	[56.8, 58.4]	[0.011, 0.081]	[-0.004, 0.110]	[0.787, 0.886]	[-0.018, 0.018]	[0.137, 0.168]
Removal of Off Street Parking Minimums	58.1%	0.044	-0.002	0.852	-0.007	0.156
	[57.3, 58.9]	[0.009, 0.079]	[-0.060, 0.056]	[0.803, 0.901]	[-0.025, 0.011]	[0.141, 0.172]
Transit-Signal Priority/Bus Lanes	57.3%	0.048	0.026	0.853	0.006	0.153
	[56.5, 58.1]	[0.014, 0.083]	[-0.031, 0.083]	[0.803, 0.903]	[-0.012, 0.024]	[0.138, 0.169]
Zero Emission Fleet Plan	57.6%	0.045	0.015	0.888	-0.005	0.149
	[56.8, 58.4]	[0.010, 0.079]	[-0.043, 0.072]	[0.837, 0.938]	[-0.023, 0.013]	[0.134, 0.165]
Full-sample Point Estimate:	**57.8%**	**0.046****	**0.024**	**0.871*****	**0.003**	**0.153*****

overwhelming majority of the 95% confidence interval ranges of the simulated distributions, and when they do not, the simulated estimates still mostly maintain the same direction and level of statistical significance. In sum, these results indicate that the paper's findings are not an artifact of the particular set of 20 policies included in the survey instrument, but reflect a more general pattern in how residents perceive and evaluate municipal policy.

Figure A.5: Results from 1,000 Simulations Randomly Dropping Five Policies from Analyses

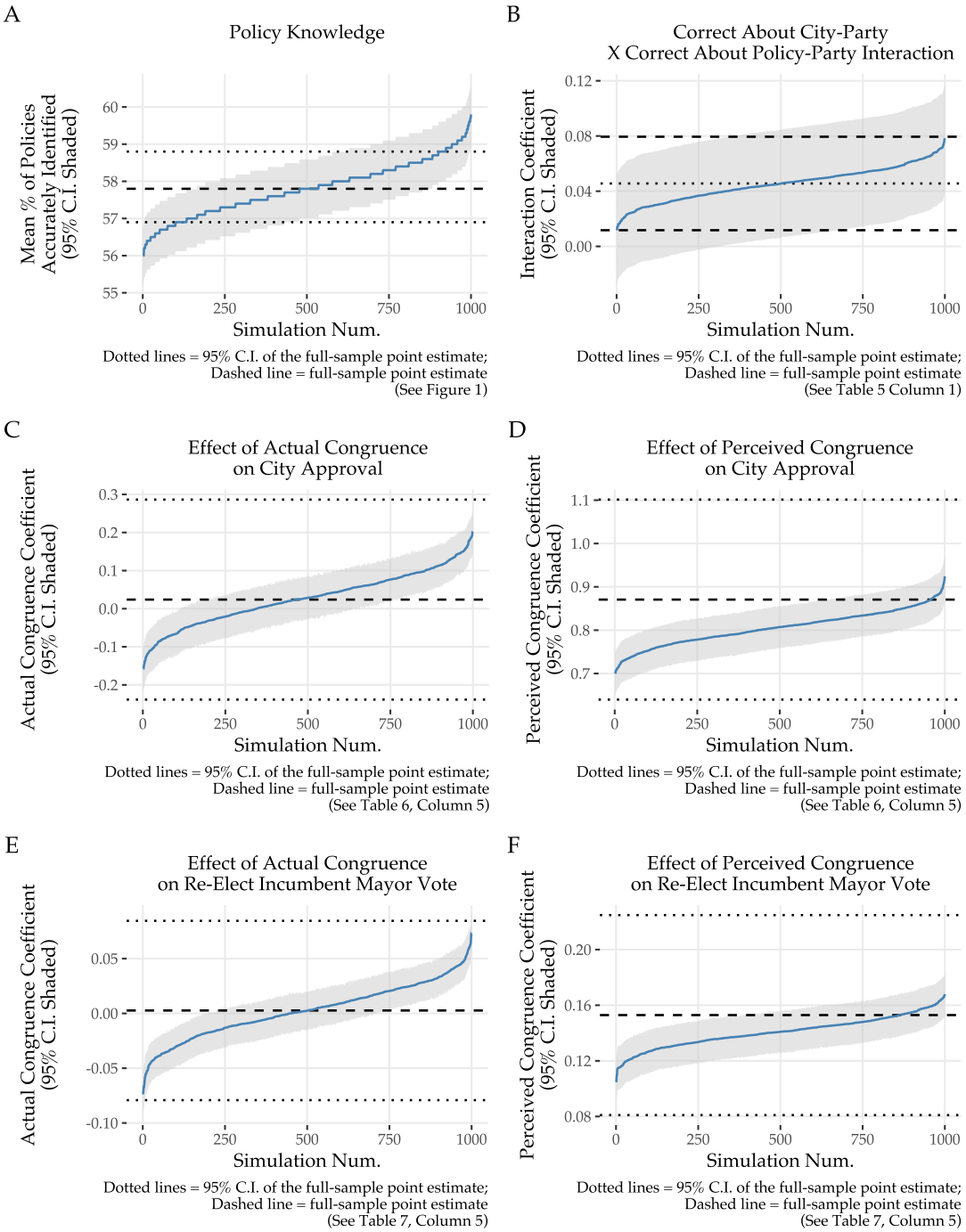
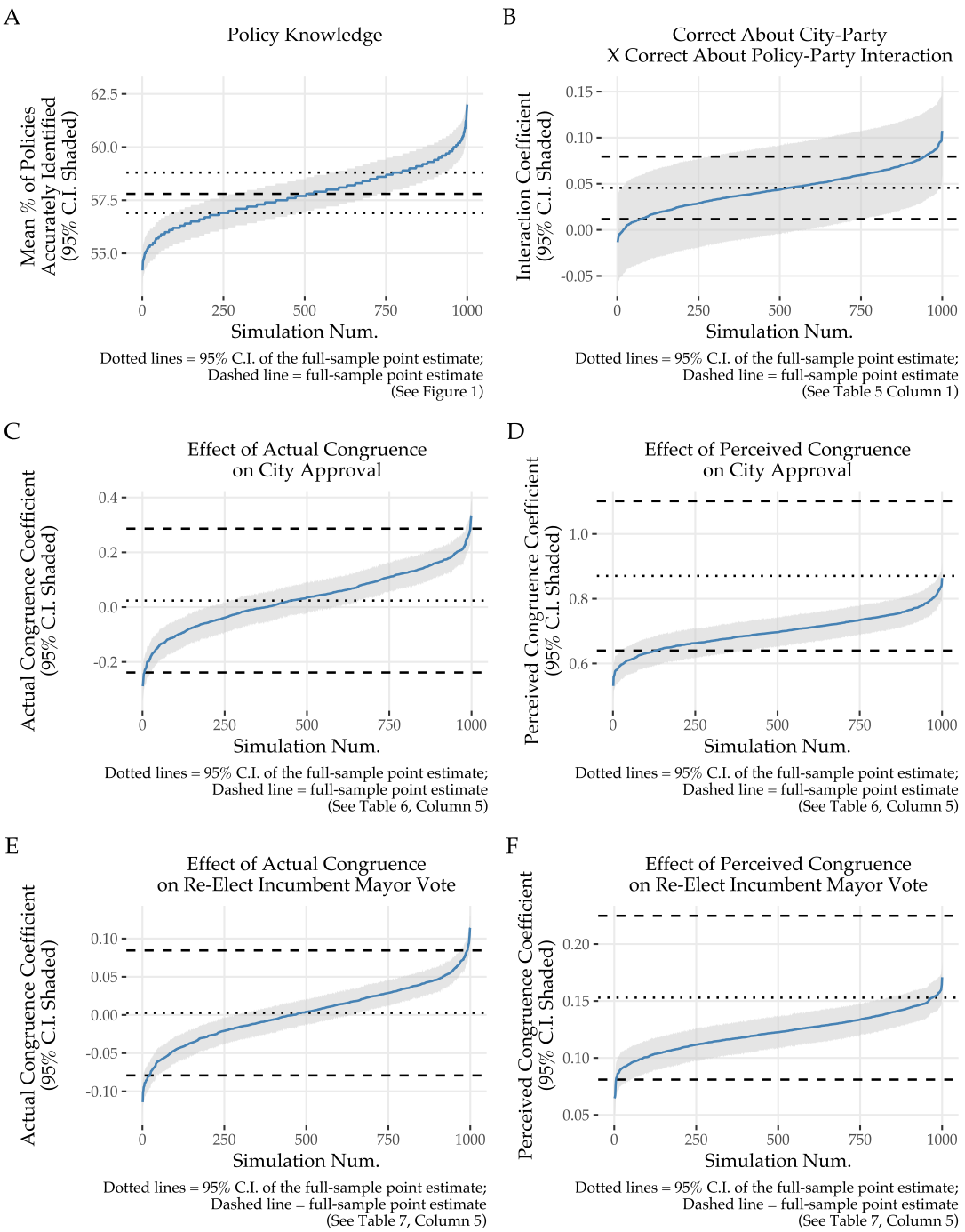


Figure A.6: Results from 1,000 Simulations Randomly Dropping 10 Policies from Analyses



A.6 Alternative Version of Figure 4

Figure 4 in the main text averages predicted probabilities of the outcome across somewhat arbitrary categories of values. Figure A.7 presents an alternative specification that does not rely on the categorical classification. Here, areas of the Figure are colored according to the predicted probability of the outcome, with darker areas representing values where the predicted probability is lower and lighter areas where it is higher. Figure A.7 can be interpreted similarly to Figure 4: respondents with higher perceptions of policy congruence, and not actual congruence, are predicted to be more willing to support the incumbent.

Figure A.7: Actual & Perceived Policy Congruence's Roles in Predicting Electoral Punishment/Reward

